



FINAL FAREWELL

S. Janaki cremated with state honours

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Sinner's reign continues

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RSS expresses concern over 'misuse of funds'

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NEED FOR CHANGES

Indian courts and vacations

When they take a break, crores of litigants wait longer for justice

EDITORIAL » PAGE 8



KEY LEADER

Qatar's Hamad bin Khalifa passes away

WORLD » PAGE 14

# Iran attacks West Asian nations after U.S. strikes

Tehran targets Bahrain, Kuwait, Qatar, Jordan, and Oman, says Strait of Hormuz is closed; U.S. says strikes will weaken Iran's ability to threaten shipping, insists traffic flowing through vital waterway

Associated Press  
DUBAI

The U.S. attacked Iran early on Sunday over an Iranian strike on a container ship in the Strait of Hormuz that left one Indian sailor missing. Iran responded with attacks on several countries in West Asia, including Bahrain, Kuwait, Qatar, Jordan, and Oman.

The U.S. struck again later on Sunday. Iran's state-run IRNA news agency cited the Governor of Qeshm island near the strait as saying projectiles had been fired at military targets, with no casualties. It said explosions were heard in the coastal city of Bandar Abbas and Hajjiabad city to the north.

The U.S. military's Central Command (CENTCOM)



The U.S. says it hit 140 targets, including missile and drone launch sites and communication equipment, in Iran. REUTERS

said it hit 140 targets, including missile and drone launch sites, ammunition dumps, communication equipment, and other sites. It said the attacks, heavier than in recent days, would weaken Iran's ability to threaten shipping. "We bombed the hell out of them last night," Pre-

sident Donald Trump said. Iranian state media later reported U.S. strikes across the country, including military sites in a province near Tehran. Semi-official news agencies said that a Navy officer was killed. Iran retaliated by attacking nations in the region hosting U.S. military forc-

## Govt. slams ship attack off Oman; seafarer missing

CHENNAI  
The government has condemned the attack on a Cyprus-flagged commercial vessel off the coast of Oman that left one of its 11 Indian crew members missing. "We condemn the attack on the commercial vessel *GFS Galaxy...*," it said. » PAGE 10

es, while insisting it alone must control the strait.

The U.S. military and Mr. Trump asserted that the strait remained open on Sunday. Iran said the strait would be closed until calm is restored.

CONTINUED ON  
» PAGE 10

## NEARBY



## I am not running away: E.V. Velu

CHENNAI  
Tiruvannamalai MLA E.V. Velu said he had travelled to Singapore for medical treatment, and was neither running away nor hiding from the DVAC. » PAGE 6

## CM to open his MLA office today

CHENNAI  
Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay will inaugurate the MLA office in his Perambur Assembly constituency on Monday. » PAGE 4

EDUCATIONPLUS » PAGE 2 & 5

# PM must restore J&K Statehood, says Omar

Peerzada Ashiq  
JAMMU

Referring to Prime Minister Narendra Modi's repeated promise to restore Statehood to Jammu and Kashmir, Chief Minister Omar Abdullah on Sunday said a commitment made by the country's highest elected leader should carry weight.

"In [Jammu's] Katra, the Prime Minister talked about the restoration of J&K Statehood, with these words that 'it isn't an ordinary promise but Modi's promise'. If the Prime Minister makes a promise, it should carry some weight, and there should be some action on it," Mr. Abdullah said at a public meeting after a rally here.

This was the second major public rally by the rul-



Omar Abdullah

ing National Conference (NC) ahead of its proposed July 20 protest at Jantar Mantar in New Delhi to demand restoration of Statehood and constitutional guarantees.

"Whenever the people of J&K seek fulfilment of the promise, we are told it will happen 'at the appropriate time'," he said.

CONTINUED ON  
» PAGE 10

# Police arrest 3 publishers for 'pro-separatist' books in J&K

The Hindu Bureau  
JAMMU

The counter-intelligence unit of the Jammu and Kashmir Police on Sunday arrested three publishers for allegedly bringing out "pro-separatist" books under the Samagra Shiksha scheme.

Officials identified the arrested persons as Inderpal, a publisher from Jammu, and Amardeep Singh and Girish Arora, both from Delhi. The police have lodged a case under Sections 49, 61 (2), 152, 196, and 353 of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita and Section 13 of the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act.

CONTINUED ON  
» PAGE 10

# Taliban seek deeper farm ties with India

Kallol Bhattacharjee  
NEW DELHI

The Taliban administration of Afghanistan has expressed desire to enhance agricultural cooperation with India, covering areas such as agricultural trade, infrastructure development, and irrigation, the External Affairs Ministry said on Sunday.

In a statement, the Ministry said the discussions took place during the six-day visit of Ataulloh Omari, the Minister for Agriculture, Irrigation and Livestock of the Taliban administration.

Among the issues discussed were cooperation



Minister Ataulloh Omari with Union Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan in New Delhi. PTI

in food processing through value addition, capacity building, and the promotion of bilateral trade in agricultural and food products.

CONTINUED ON  
» PAGE 10

# IIT-M told to disclose grant-in-aid fund use

S. Vijay Kumar  
CHENNAI

The Central Information Commission (CIC) has directed the Indian Institute of Technology-Madras (IIT-M) to provide a detailed, project-wise breakdown of the utilisation of grant-in-aid funds for the financial year 2023-24 sought under the Right to Information (RTI) Act, 2005.

The direction came on a petition filed by Ananya Dubey, who sought details of the grant-in-aid received by the institute over the previous three financial years, along with project-wise utilisation of the funds, copies of utilisation

certificates, and the names of collaborations that IIT-M entered into.

The Central Public Information Officer (CPIO) initially declined the request, arguing that the information sought for three years was voluminous and retrieving and compiling it would disproportionately divert the institute's resources. The applicant was asked to narrow the scope of her request by specifying the period and information required. Following this, Ms. Dubey restricted her request to the fiscal 2023-24.

CONTINUED ON  
» PAGE 6

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INBRIEF



State-level conference held on non-communicable diseases

Sri Ramachandra Institute of Higher Education and Research (SRIHER), in association with the Indian Association of Preventive and Social Medicine (IAPSM) - Tamil Nadu Chapter, organised an annual state conference from July 9 to 11 in the city. According to a press release, the three-day conference brought together more than 250 delegates and over 50 renowned speakers under the theme “Integrating Public Health and Clinical Care for Control of Non-Communicable Diseases.” Inaugurating the conference, A. Somasundaram, Director of Public Health and Preventive Medicine, noted the steady increase in the State’s urban population and stressed the need to strengthen public health interventions in urban areas. He said that Tamil Nadu has established 708 Urban Health and Wellness Centres to improve access to care.

Man dies after touching live electric wire, friend critical

A 28-year-old man was electrocuted, and his friend suffered an electric shock and is battling for life in Neelankarai on Saturday. Police said R. Ravikumar and M. Muthukumar had been staying in a rented a property in Vettuvankeni of Neelankarai for over a month. On Saturday night, as both of them were consuming liquor and talking on the terrace, Ravikumar went to the edge of the terrace and accidentally touched a live overhead wire. He was electrocuted, and Muthukumar also received electric shock while trying to save him. Neighbours rushed to help and sent them to Perumbakkam Government Hospital where the doctors pronounced that Ravikumar had died. Muthukumar is undergoing treatment at Government Kilpauk Medical College Hospital.

ECO WATCH

Geetha Srimathi  
CHENNAI

Morning walkers circle Raman Thangal Lake in Sholinganallur, but instead of the shade promised by rows of transplanted trees, they are greeted by a line of lifeless trunks.

Over a year after nearly 95 trees, most of which were mature adult trees, were relocated there by the Highways Department during road widening works, most have failed to survive.

The transplantation was carried out between March and May 2025 after the Highways Department relocated several trees to facilitate the widening of the ECR between Akkarai and Thiruvanniyur.

A recent visit to the lake found rows of dead trunks with no signs of fresh leaves, shoots or new growth, indicating that most of the trees had dried up after the transplantation. Tree transplantation and compensatory plantation are commonly undertaken as mitigation measures when infrastructure projects require the removal of mature trees. However,



Gone forever: Environmentalists also pointed out that transplantation can succeed only if the relocated trees receive intensive aftercare for several months after they are moved. S.R. RAGHUNATHAN

er, environmentalists point out that transplantation can succeed only if the trees receive intensive aftercare for several months after they are moved.

T.D. Babu of Nizhal, a Chennai-based environmental organisation, said, “The place has become a graveyard of trees. The location itself is good because it is next to a waterbody, so water availability should not have been a problem. But there are no new leaves, shoots or sprouts.”

Mr. Babu explained that

transplantation places trees under severe stress because a significant portion of their root system is damaged during excavation and relocation. After transplantation, they require growth promoters, anti-fungal treatment, organic manure and regular watering to maintain soil moisture.

“They should be monitored until they put out new leaves. At the very least, they need careful maintenance through one full summer,” he said.

Environmentalists say

the District Green Committee should periodically review tree transplantation projects to monitor survival rates and fix accountability where maintenance has been neglected.

‘Fix accountability’

They say that the agencies responsible for transplantation should be held accountable when trees die due to poor aftercare.

An official from the Highways Department acknowledged the issue and said the matter would be looked into.



The conference brought together neurologists, neurosurgeons, patients, and caregivers. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Experts call for wider access to incision-free Parkinson’s treatment

The Hindu Bureau  
CHENNAI

An incision-free, ultrasound-based treatment for Parkinson’s disease and other movement disorders, widely used abroad but still scarcely available in India, could significantly improve patients’ quality of life, experts said at the NeuroNext Forum organised by the Vattikuti Foundation on Sunday.

Speaking at the conference, Aniruddha Bhagwat, neurosurgeon at Deenanath Mangeshkar Hospital, Pune, said that Magnetic Resonance-guided Focused Ultrasound (MRgFUS), an U.S. FDA-approved treatment, remains largely inaccessible in India.

He said the treatment is particularly suitable for patients with Parkinson’s disease or Essential Tremor whose symptoms are not adequately controlled with medication or who experience severe drug side ef-

fects. Abhinav Vattikutti of the Vattikuti Foundation said, “Through the NeuroNext Forum, we aim to bridge the gap between medical expertise and the people who need it most by enabling patients and caregivers to engage with specialists and better understand their treatment journey.”

Gopal Krishna, consultant neurosurgeon at KIMS Hospital, said the procedure is especially beneficial for older adults because it does not involve surgical incisions, stitches or drilling into the skull.

Doctors said the treatment can significantly improve daily life by reducing tremors.

They added that MRgFUS is performed on only one side of the brain to symptoms on the opposite side of the body. Treatment of the other side may be considered after six to nine months, depending on the patient’s condition and disease severity.

Govt. issues SOP for initiating action against unauthorised institutions in health sector

The Hindu Bureau  
CHENNAI

The State government has issued a Standard Operating Procedure (SOP) for identifying and initiating action against unauthorised institutions in the health sector.

The Health Department, in an order issued recently, said complaints were received about certain institutions operating

without approval of the Central or State government, affiliation to a recognised University, a recognition from the competent statutory council or board. Among institutions that have obtained approval, certain courses were being offered without requisite affiliation, recognition or statutory sanction.

The issue spans the full range of health education, including medicine, den-

tistry, nursing, pharmacy, allied healthcare, rehabilitation sciences, Indian Systems of Medicine (ayurveda, siddha, unani), homeopathy, yoga, naturopathy, and public health. According to the order, such institutions often mislead students into enrolling in such courses at a high cost, resulting in financial loss, academic uncertainty and long-term damage to their careers.

Despite earlier government instructions, such institutions continue to operate in various places, prompting the need for an SOP. It proposes to establish a uniform and clearly defined operational framework for district-level action. The objective is to adopt procedures for taking action on the violations through legal process.

Under the SOP, the Joint Director of Health Services

(JDHS) will serve as the nodal officer at the district level for implementation of the SOP. Every year on April 1, the Registrar of Tamil Nadu Dr. MGR Medical University, Directorate of Medical Education and Research, Directorate of Public Health and Preventive Medicine and Directorate of Indian Medicine must provide the JDHS with district-wise lists of approved institutions and courses.

In case of a complaint, the JDHS will constitute an inspection team to visit the institutions and verify whether the institution is authorised, whether each course offered has the required approvals and examine student admission records, fee collection and infrastructure and clinical training facilities. The report should be submitted to the District Collector.

If the violations are con-

firmed, the JDHS will submit a factual report to the Collector. After the Collector’s approval, a complaint will be filed with the Superintendent or Commissioner of Police for action.

The Collector should take steps to prevent further admission to unauthorised institutions or unapproved courses, and wherever warranted, order the closure of such institution after following

due legal process. The SOP also requires the directorates to publish updated lists of approved institutions and courses on their websites every April 1. The JDHS should periodically compile and circulate the list within the district to the Collector, while institutions must prominently display their statutory approvals, recognitions, and affiliation on their premises and official websites.

Association of private schools urges govt. to institute State-level Best Teacher Awards

The Hindu Bureau  
CHENNAI

The School Voice Association, the association of all private schools in Tamil Nadu, have requested the School Education Minister to institute ‘Tamil Nadu Best Teacher Awards’.

In a petition to the Minister, the association said, “The proposal seeks to extend State-level recognition to deserving teachers from all recognised school education boards – including play schools, nursery and primary, matriculation, matriculation higher secondary, CBSE, CBSE Senior Secondary, IGCSE, and Cambridge International Schools – across all 38 districts of Tamil Nadu.”

They noted that the State government has been awarding the Dr. Radhakrishnan Best Teacher Award to government school teachers since the 1970s, and then extended it to Matriculation and Anglo-Indian Schools.

Pointing out that the education landscape in the State has undergone vast

changes, the general secretary of the association, M.J. John Arokia Prabhu said that over 50% of the students in the State are now studying in private unaided schools, according to recent reports.

‘Lack of recognition’

“Thousands of highly dedicated teachers serving in these recognised private institutions contribute immensely to quality education. Despite their remarkable service, teachers belonging to many school boards do not have an opportunity to receive State-level recognition under the existing award structure,” the petition stated.

The association said that a State-level award for a teacher in the eight categories including play school teacher, nursery and primary school teacher, IGCSE school teacher and Cambridge International school teacher, should be given.

They also requested the Minister to constitute a transparent District-Level Selection Committees for each category.

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On 14<sup>th</sup> July 6:00 pm: Inauguration Sri N.Ravi, Chairman, Bhavan's Chennai Kendra presides. Dr.Nallu Kuppuswami Chetti, Vice-Chairman Welcomes. Kalaimamani Kum.Sachu (Veteran actress) receives the "Yakkunar Sigaram K.Balachander Award" (Instituted by Kavithalayaa Sri T.Krishnan), followed by UAA's 'Varadu Kutty-Parthakkattu Naramachu - 2' on 15<sup>th</sup> July. The Res.'Kasthminilayam Geetham' on 16<sup>th</sup> July. KNT presents 'Neera' on 17<sup>th</sup> July. TV Varadarajan & Team presents "Sangeetha Mumorthigal". The dramas will be staged every day at 6.45 pm. All are Welcome.

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Rasika Ranjani Sabha Foundation, Ch-4.

Today at 6.15 p.m. Adiyargal Adicuvattil Madhusudan Kalaichelvan and Sargurunathan Oduvar present Muvar Patiya Anaikka. Ph. No: 86103 57987. Rasikas Welcome.

MISCELLANEOUS

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It is hereby informed to the general public that our client proposes to purchase and develop the property mentioned in the Schedule hereunder owned by Franc India Shoe Factory, acting through Mr. Vinodh Bhatla.

SCHEDULE

Property being land of an extent of 11 acres 12 cents, in Old Survey No. 225/1 (part), presently Survey No. 225/1A1B1, Situate at EGUVARPALAYAM Village, Gummidipoondi Taluk, Tiruvallur District and within the Sub - Registration District of Gummidipoondi and Registration District of Tiruvallur.

The present owner represents that the said property was earlier, purchased by the firm Franc India Shoe Factory under a Sale Deed dated 22.05.1985, bearing Doc. No. 532/1985, registered at the Sub-Registrar of Chennai Central Joint-1, later, the said firm was dissolved on 07.12.1998 and since then the said firm has been converted into a proprietor concern and the assets of the firm was in the hands of Mr. Vinodh Bhatla, son of Mr. Ramji Das Bhatla and since then the said Mr. Vinodh Bhatla, representing as proprietor of Franc India Shoe Factory, has been in absolute ownership, possession, and enjoyment of the property. Further the present owner assures that the said property is free from all encumbrances, claims and demands and the said property is not subject to any agreements, charges, litigations tenants and liens and except them no other person or persons have any right, title or interest over the said property.

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Chennai 13-07-2026

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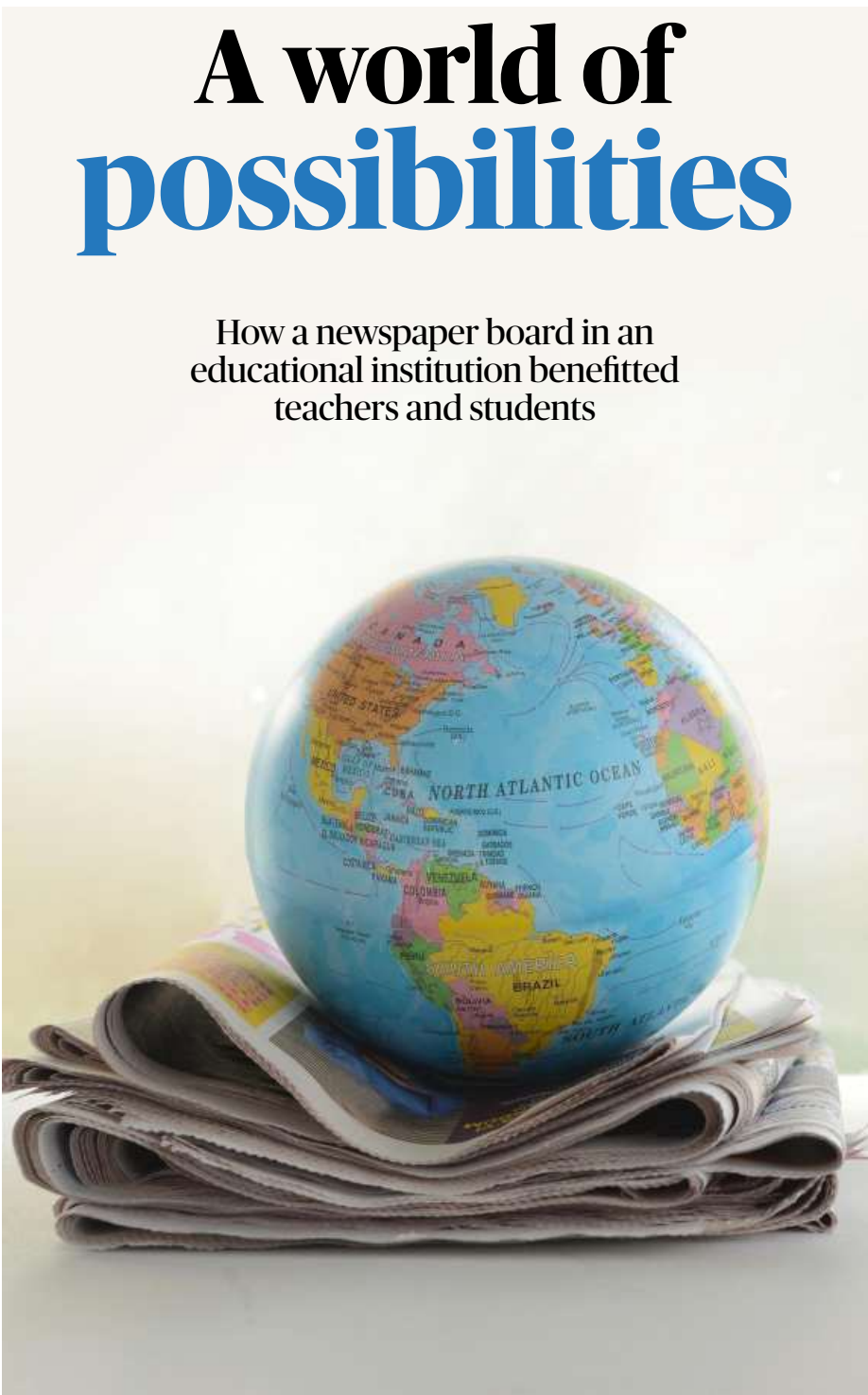
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Nimesh Ved

Recently, a board was installed at our institution to put up newspaper articles. The idea was to encourage students and teachers to read newspapers. Actually, to just read. We began with an open mind and four dailies. We were keen to get to know of the developments in the country and the subjects we pursued.

**Introducing themes**  
We began by reading and rereading the newspapers, short-listing articles, pondering over them, and neatly putting them up on the boards. In the course of a few weeks, we increased the board area and made it more reader-friendly. ‘Shall we read?’ talked of parents’ and book stores’ efforts to increase reading. We were doing our bit here. Next came the themes.  
AI is extensively written about these days. We put up articles on how it reinforces gender and caste biases (Sociology) or even on how it discourages creativity. We also had articles on the water guzzling and carbon footprint (Education for Sustainable Development) that go into the development of AI. The details and the numbers left all of us surprised.  
Civics followed. Newspapers had extensively covered the municipal elections in the state. This helped us discuss political parties, youth participation, voting practices, results, fair elections and democracy as a whole. We realised that our awareness of local bodies was not so



GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCKPHOTO

something we could be proud of. Leopards were all over the landscape and the news, so they got dedicated space (EVS). We talked about how these sightings have a seasonal trend, possible long-term solutions at

a landscape level and so on. This was of avid interest, especially as a leopard was trapped by the forest department not far from the institution.  
**Importance of history**  
The idea behind having History on the board was to underscore that the subject was alive and being discussed as it impacted our present and future. The articles talked of new galleries coming up in museums, new evidence uncovered in excavations, conserving and displaying significant relics, and even a ‘Return to Harappa’, which talked about toy kits around history. History was not exactly popular and some students would ask why they needed to learn history. These discussions helped address that, to some extent.  
The ongoing debates in the country during the period were extensively covered in the newspapers: the Vande Mataram controversy, UGC regulations, Keezhadi excavations, the changes to the NCERT textbooks, what was going on with the Aravallis, and even the Preamble to the Constitution. These presented an opportunity for the classroom to engage with topics being discussed elsewhere, to read views and opinions of others, and agree/ disagree with them. More importantly, to learn to agree and disagree.  
Then there were articles on books: reviews, author interviews, reports on literature festivals and reading. Among authors who got space were Salman Rushdie, Kiran Desai, and Satoshi Yagisawa, who had new books and Hindi wri-

ter Vinod Kumar Shukla, who passed away.  
To our surprise, the most popular article was the one on the Japanese automobile company Suzuki making and selling Indian curries in Japan. Initially, we were unsure whether this was for real, but the article led to discussions about innovation and collaboration.

**Benefits**  
At one level, the entire exercise was about skimming through newspapers, reading shortlisted articles, pondering over them, putting them up neatly on the boards, and learning about the country. At another level, however, it was about realising that newspapers talk about and mirror the world, which is doing what it has always done: change and evolve. It was up to us to decide what we took from the newspaper. To me, personally, reading newspapers benefited my students and me.  
We had taken the initial steps. We could connect the articles with our experiences (travel, reading, conversations), or read further on topics of interest, or learn the language (including how to write better), or take cognisance of the changes around us (new writers aka fresh voices emerging, cultural spaces coming up in cities), and be aware of the worlds beyond the small world we inhabit in a society that is increasing getting more insular.  
The writer has been an educator and administrator in education institutions.

## SCHOLARSHIPS

**Inlaks Fine Arts Awards**  
Offered by the Inlaks Shivdasani Foundation  
**Eligibility:** Indian passport holders or those currently residing in India born on or after January 1, 1996 who are emerging artists or a recent graduate or postgraduate in visual arts or a final-year student enrolled in an Indian visual arts institute.  
**Rewards:** ₹300,000/ year  
**Application:** Online  
**Deadline:** August 15  
www.b4s.in/edge/IFAAl

**Schaeffler India Hope Engineering Scholarship**  
Offered by Schaeffler India.  
**Eligibility:** Female students enrolled in the first year of an Engineering programme at a government-recognised college with at least 60% in Class 12 (Science stream) in 2025-26 (40% for PwD applicants) and an annual family income not exceeding ₹500,000.

**Rewards:** ₹50,000 a year for four years.  
**Application:** Online  
**Deadline:** August 15  
www.b4s.in/edge/SIHEI7

**Indus Towers Scholarship**  
A CSR initiative by Indus Towers Ltd. (formerly Bharti Infratel).  
**Eligibility:** Indian nationals with a benchmark disability of 40% or more who are pursuing an eligible course, including higher secondary, graduation, PG, Master's, Diploma, certificate, vocational and skill development programmes, or coaching for employment-oriented competitive exams and have got 45% in the qualifying exam and belong to the BPL or EWS categories with an annual family income not exceeding ₹800,000.  
**Rewards:** Up to ₹75,000.  
**Application:** Online  
**Deadline:** August 22  
www.b4s.in/edge/ITSP5

Courtesy: Buddy4study.com

## Conference

The British Council is organising the South Asia TeachingEnglish Online Conference 2026.  
This free three-day event will bring together educators, researchers and teachers from Bangladesh, India, Nepal, Pakistan and Sri Lanka to examine one of the most pressing questions facing

education today: how can schools equip learners with the creativity, adaptability and communication skills needed to thrive in an increasingly complex world and how emerging technologies, including AI, can be harnessed to enhance rather than replace human-centred teaching.  
**Dates:** July 23-25  
For details, visit <https://shorturl.at/sEZx8>

## SAVE THE DATE

**Admissions**  
**MIT World Peace University (MIT-WPU)** has launched the Hafeez Contractor School of Architecture to offer industry-aligned programmes. Admissions for its five-year B.Arch are now open. Scholarships are available.  
**Eligibility:** Minimum 50% aggregate in Classes 10 and 12 with English, Physics and Maths as compulsory subjects with either Chemistry, Biology, Technical Vocational subject, Computer Science, Information Technology, Informatics Practices, Engineering Graphics, Business Studies as other subjects OR minimum 60% aggregate in 10+3 Diploma in Engineering and Technology with Maths from a government-approved technical board; valid scores in JEE 2026 (B.Arch); 500-word statement of purpose  
**Deadline:** July 18  
<https://shorturl.at/B7bIk>

**Tetr College** has launched a Global Gap Year Programme, a 40-week international experience designed to bring greater structure and purpose to the traditional gap year. Spanning nine countries across Asia, Africa, South America and Europe, the programme is designed for students looking to explore entrepreneurial interests, gain international exposure, and learn through real-world experiences. The inaugural cohort is scheduled to commence in October 2026. Applications are now open. Open to students in the 18+ age group.  
<https://shorturl.at/zGdzJ>

**Nagaland University** invites applications for admission to its Four-Year B.Sc. Undergraduate Programme (FYUGP) for the 2026-27 academic session through CUET-UG 2026. The Undergraduate programme offers students the flexibility to pursue Honours and Honours with Research programmes in five disciplines: Botany, Chemistry, Mathematics, Physics, and Zoology. Admissions will be based on CUET-UG scores and Class 12 exam marks.  
<https://shorturl.at/mEbCH>

The **University of Sheffield, the U.K.**, invites ing applications for its M.Sc. Cognitive and Computational Neuroscience course starting in September 2026. Scholarships are available.  
**Eligibility:** Three- or four-year Bachelor's degree with minimum 60% in Behavioural Neuroscience, Cognitive Neuroscience, Computational Neuroscience, Neuroimaging, Neuropharmacology, Neuroscience and Psychology; Overall IELTS score of 6.5 with 6 in each component.  
**Deadline:** September 1

<https://tinyurl.com/thzapxmu>

**ESCP and Sciences Po** have launched a new dual bachelor's degree in Politics, Economics and Management (PEM) delivered entirely in English over four years. The first two years will be at Sciences Po's Reims Campus in France, the third at ESCP London, and the final year at one of ESCP's European campuses.  
**Eligibility:** A French Baccalaureate or an international equivalent; English proficiency at C1 level.  
<https://tinyurl.com/xcxcw53>

**Strathclyde Business School**, Glasgow, the U.K., is offering scholarships to support full-time international students joining an M.Sc. programme in Accounting and Finance, Business, Data Analytics, Management, Management science, Marketing, in January 2027.  
**Eligibility:** Candidates must be self-funded and already hold an offer of a place on an SBS M.Sc. programme for the January 2027 intake and also be deemed International with regards to Fee Status. Online and blended learning programmes are not eligible for these scholarships.  
**Deadline:** November 30  
<https://tinyurl.com/46z34vmh>

**Hack Core 2026**  
ANNAM.AI - India's first Centre of

Excellence (CoE) for Artificial Intelligence in Agriculture, hosted at IIT Ropar under the Ministry of Education, Government of India - has launched HACK CORE 2026, a national AI hackathon in collaboration with Syngenta and Google. It invites students, researchers, developers and others to develop AI-driven solutions for crop health, pest management, soil intelligence, climate-resilient farming, and the wider adoption of biological products across India. The winning team will also be taken to visit the Syngenta's Research Centre in Atesa, Italy.  
**Deadline:** July 21.  
<https://shorturl.at/8T6Qu>

**Sona Star Innovation**, in partnership with the **University of West Alabama**, the U.S., has launched the SonaUWA 1+1 International Pathway Programme through which students can pursue the second year of MS in Data Science programme at the UWA campus in Alabama, after completing their first year at Sona Centre for Advanced Learning and Entrepreneurship, Bengaluru.  
**Eligibility:** B.Tech or B.E. students from CSE, IT, AI & ML, Data Science, ECE, or related branches or B.Sc, BCA, MCA, M.Sc students with strong quantitative and programming skills.  
**Deadline:** September 5  
Details at <https://scaleindia.in/sona-uwa>

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**DURATION :**  
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**ELIGIBILITY :**  
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**ELIGIBILITY :**  
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CM YK A CH-CE



From Page One

IIT-M told to disclose grant-in-aid fund use

The CPIO informed her that IIT-M had received ₹537 crore towards sponsored research projects and ₹241 crore for industry research projects during the period. The reply stated that the funds had been utilised in accordance with the sanction orders or agreements of the sponsoring agencies. However, the CPIO said copies of utilisation certificates could not be disclosed without the concurrence of the respective sponsoring agencies, while information relating to collaborations was not readily available.

Project-wise utilisation details

Contending that the institute had failed to furnish the project-wise utilisation details of the grant-in-aid, Ms. Dubey approached the CIC. During the hearing, the CPIO submitted that IIT-M had handled more than 1,000 projects during the relevant period, some of which were yet to attain finality, and any unutilised funds, wherever applicable, would have to be returned to the government. He also argued that project-wise fund utilisation details and related agreements contained third-party personal information which was exempted from disclosure under Section 8(1) (j) of the Act. Information Commissioner Sudha Rani Relangi noted that the request for information on the utilisation of grant-in-aid funds had not been addressed adequately. Recording the CPIO's willingness to revisit the matter, she directed the officer to issue a revised, categorical reply to the petitioner, addressing in particular her request for the utilisation details of the grant-in-aid funds for 2023-24.

Vietnam boat tragedy: Tiruchi, Salem, Vellore, Tiruvannamalai residents among those killed

While three persons from Tiruchi died in the accident, one each from Salem, Vellore, and Tiruvannamalai were among the deceased. Tamil Nadu All Mobiles Retailers Association has requested the representatives of Lava Mobiles to expedite the procedures to shift the mortal remains to the State

**The Hindu Bureau**  
TIRUCHI/SALEM/VELLORE/  
CHENNAI

Residents of Tiruchi, Salem, Vellore, and Tiruvannamalai districts were among the 10 tourists from Tamil Nadu who were killed when a boat cap-sized near Phu Quoc Island in Vietnam on Saturday. N. Balaji, 44, a resident of Thiruvanaikovil in Tiruchi, was a B. Com graduate and a manager at Sellmore Marketing Private Limited in Ariyamangalam. He had travelled to Vietnam, along with his colleagues, as part of an incentive trip organised by Lava Mobiles. “We were waiting for him to return home in two days. This news has shattered us,” his uncle Govindarajan told *The Hindu*. Balaji had left for Vietnam on the night of July 8. He was the sole breadwinner of the family and is survived

by his mother, wife, and two sons aged 13 and 10. Family members said his employer had been in touch with the authorities and was coordinating efforts related to the incident. The family is now awaiting the repatriation of his mortal remains from Vietnam. A.M. Sheikh Abdullah, a 56-year-old Tiruchi resident, was also among the victims. He is survived by his wife and two children. Sheikh Abdullah ran a distribution agency of Lava Mobiles products in the city and had travelled to Vietnam as part of the business tour hosted by the parent company. S. Alagurajan, 38, a sales manager for Lava Mobiles overseeing Tiruchi, Karur, and Thanjavur districts, was another of the victims. He is a resident of Crawford and is survived by his wife and two sons. He had travelled to Vietnam on the



(From left) A.M. Sheikh Abdullah, N. Balaji, and S. Alagurajan, all residents of Tiruchi. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

company-sponsored trip after achieving a three-month sales target. The family learnt about the tragedy only around 3 p.m. through members of the Tiruchi Mobile Sangam. “We have spoken to Minister Ramesh, who assured us that steps would be taken immediately to facilitate the return of the mortal remains,” said Ragunath, his colleague. M. Shahul Hameed, senior vice-president, Tamil

Nadu All Mobiles Retailers Association, told *The Hindu* that the industry body had requested representatives of Lava Mobiles to be present in Vietnam and expedite the procedures to repatriate the mortal remains of the victims at the earliest. “We have been informed that the survivors of the excursion would begin returning to India by Sunday afternoon (July 12, 2026). The bodies of the 15

Indian nationals may be sent back by Tuesday or Wednesday,” he said. Sridhar, 62, from Salem district was also among the victims. Sridhar, a resident of Ramakrishna Road in Salem, was a mobile phone dealer with an office at Alagapuram. He is survived by wife, a son, and a daughter. Two other victims, C. Vinaya Kumar, 45, and S. Ravisankar, 51, were from Vellore and Tiruvannamalai districts respectively. A resident of Saidapet in the Vellore Corporation, Vinaya Kumar ran a jewellery shop on Lang Bazar Road opposite the fort complex and was the main distributor of Lava Mobiles in the district. “He spoke to his wife and daughter on Saturday morning, informing them that he will return the next morning. We never expected this news,” Prabhakaran, Vinaya Kumar's father-in-law, told *The Hindu*.

Ravisankar was a distributor for Lava PNG Agency in Tiruvannamalai town. Son of a wholesale merchant, Ravisankar was the sole breadwinner of the family. The family learnt about the tragedy through the media before they were officially informed by the Centre on Saturday. He is survived by his wife and two children. **‘Facilitate repatriation’** Former BJP State president K. Annamalai on Sunday condoled the deaths in the boat accident and urged the Union and Tamil Nadu governments to shift the mortal remains of the 10 victims belonging to Tamil Nadu to the State. He also urged the governments to ensure medical treatment to those who were injured in the accident. In a social media post, Mr. Annamalai expressed his deep condolences to the bereaved families.

I am neither running away nor hiding, says E.V. Velu

**The Hindu Bureau**  
CHENNAI

Tiruvannamalai DMK MLA and former Minister E.V. Velu said on Sunday that he had travelled to Singapore for medical treatment and he was neither running away nor hiding. He said he was prepared to appear before the Directorate of Vigilance and Anti-Corruption (DVAC) on any day after Sunday. “We were not groomed in such a manner either by our leader Kalaigarr [M. Karunanidhi] or former Chief Minister M.K. Stalin,” he said after his return from Singapore. Displaying his medical records, Mr. Velu said he had been receiving treatment for heart ailments at Mount Elizabeth Hospital in Singapore since 2016. He said Jayaram Lingamnaicker, a Tamil doctor who heads the department, had been overseeing his treatment. He had also visited the hospital in 2023.



Mr. Velu said that after the strenuous campaign for the Assembly election, he planned to undergo a check-up in Singapore. He applied for a visa on June 15, obtained it on June 17, and booked his flight for June 25. However, before his departure, the police visited his residence with a search warrant. “I cooperated fully with the police. I informed them of my travel plans and postponed my departure to June 26,” he said. In Singapore, he underwent medical examinations for allergies and neurological and cardiac

After the strenuous campaign for the Assembly election, I planned to undergo a check-up in Singapore. I have the medical summary and all the relevant records

E.V. VELU  
Tiruvannamalai MLA

conditions. “I have the medical summary and all the relevant records,” he said. Mr. Velu said a summons had been affixed to his residence directing him to appear before the DVAC on July 3. “I informed the DVAC that I would require 10 days. Subsequently, I was asked to appear on July 9. I again replied that I was ready to cooperate with the inquiry after July 12. There is no question of my running away or hiding,” he said. He said there was no need to target him as he was the whip of the DMK in the Assembly.

**T. Ramakrishnan**  
CHENNAI

Tamil Nadu drew a lower quantity of rice than the quota allocated for Antyodaya Anna Yojana (AAY) cardholders in five of the last seven years under the public distribution system. In this context, Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay's request to Prime Minister Narendra Modi not to disturb the existing provision assumes significance. Of the five years (from 2019-20 to 2025-26), it was during the COVID-19 pandemic year (2020-21) that the drawal was almost close to the allocated figure of around 6.99 lakh tonnes, with the off-take being about 98%. In the remaining four years, it varied from around 73% during 2022-23 and 2023-24 to 79% during 2024-25. Only in two years (2019-20 and 2025-26) did the utilisation exceed the allocated quantity, close to 108%. Between 2020 and

Foodgrain quota

Allocation and drawal under Antyodaya Anna Yojana in Tamil Nadu over the years

| Year    | Allocation | Offtake (drawal) | Offtake % |
|---------|------------|------------------|-----------|
| 2019-20 | 6,89,246   | 7,50,046         | 108.82    |
| 2020-21 | 6,99,628   | 6,86,052         | 98.06     |
| 2021-22 | 7,04,819   | 5,42,877         | 77.02     |
| 2022-23 | 7,43,975   | 5,50,171         | 73.95     |
| 2023-24 | 7,51,547   | 5,52,537         | 73.52     |
| 2024-25 | 7,38,492   | 5,85,126         | 79.23     |
| 2025-26 | 7,39,718   | 8,01,574         | 108.36    |



SOURCE: FOODGRAIN BULLETINS ISSUED BY THE DEPARTMENT OF FOOD AND PUBLIC DISTRIBUTION OF THE UNION GOVERNMENT.

2023, the Union government implemented the Pradhan Mantri Garib Kalyan Anna Yojana (PMGKAY) to provide free foodgrains in addition to the regular allocation in view of the pandemic.

**Centre criticises T.N.** In those years, Tamil Nadu came under criticism of the Union government that it had made more use of the free foodgrains than its regular allocation as rice

was then supplied to the State at ₹3 per kg for AAY and priority household (PHH) cards. Since January 1, 2023, the Union government has not been charging any amount for rice meant for the two categories of cards. It has extended, for five years effective January 1, 2024, the period of distribution of free foodgrains, the arrangement of which is named as the PMGKAY.

A stunning stone window at Sadaimudinathar Temple showcases skill of Chola-era sculptors

**B. Kolappan**  
CHENNAI

It might be an apocryphal tale in the region, and yet it is one that speaks volumes about the extraordinary skill of the sculptors who created the celebrated stone window (*palakani*) at the *Nurai* (white) *Pillaiyar* shrine within the Sadaimudinathar Temple at Tiruvalanchuzhi, the *Vavval Nathi Mandapam* at Tiruveezhimizhalai Temple, and the remarkable *Kondungai* (sunshade) *Mandapam* at Avudaiyar Koil. “Master craftsmen, while entering into agreements with their patrons, would promise to reproduce any architectural element—but would exclude these three masterpieces. Such was the exceptional craftsmanship involved that even the ace sculptors acknowledged they could never replicate them,” said Kabartheeswara Gurukkal of the temple. Anyone who visits the



**Intricate design:** The stone lattice window, known as a *palakani*, of the *Nurai Pillaiyar* shrine on the Sadaimudinathar Temple premises in Tiruvalanchuzhi near Kumbakonam. R. VENGADESH

*Nurai Pillaiyar* shrine at Tiruvalanchuzhi in Thanjavur district will understand why. The exquisitely carved stone window, a masterpiece of the later Chola period, continues to inspire awe and stands as one of the finest achievements of south Indian temple architecture. R. Kalaikovan of the Dr. Rajamanickanar Centre for Historical Research said there were about 50 in-

scriptions referring to the *Pillaiyar* shrine. The earliest of them date to the reign of Kulotunga III. However, all these inscriptions are found on the walls of the Sadaimudinathar Temple, within whose precincts the shrine is situated. “In the window, there are four stone pillars connected by intricate lattice work, crowned with sculptures of *yazhis*. The two central pillars are each

**There are about 50 inscriptions referring to the *Pillaiyar* shrine with the stone lattice window on the walls of Sadaimudinathar Temple**

carved from a single block of stone, while the two flanking pillars are fashioned as half-pillars. They are interlocked with floral motifs and lattice work arranged in four rectangular panels,” write R. Kalakovan and Nalini in *Valanchuzhi Vanar*, their book on the Sadaimudinathar Temple. The western window, however, is markedly different from its eastern counterpart. It lacks the elaborate ornamentation that makes the eastern window one of the temple's most admired architectural features. The temple as a whole, and particularly its *mandapa*, is a monumental testa-

ment to the genius of Chola sculptors. Even the stone roof has been fashioned with such precision that it appears to have been crafted by a master carpenter working in wood rather than by a sculptor chiselling granite. The extended architectural structures of the *Pillaiyar* shrine, known as *panjaras*, have been transformed into miniature shrine-like structures. Each *panjara* is distinguished by a unique lattice pattern and enshrined a finely sculpted female figure, reflecting the sculptors' remarkable imagination. The northern *panjara* alone is devoid of a female figure, while those in the remaining *panjaras* have suffered extensive damage over the centuries. Yet even in their mutilated state, they retain an arresting grace that bears testimony to the artistic brilliance of the craftsmen of the Chola era.

Ilaiyaraaja, P. Susheela pay rich tributes to S. Janaki

**The Hindu Bureau**  
CHENNAI

Film music director Ilaiyaraaja said veteran playback singer S. Janaki, who passed away on July 11, 2026, had proved through every song she sang that she was second to none in talent. In a recorded video message posted on social media on Sunday, the legendary composer said he was deeply saddened by Janaki's death. “The news came as a great shock to me. It is painful to know that she endured countless personal tragedies in her life. Many great composers and musical geniuses across the world have gone through immense hardships,” said Ilaiyaraaja, who collaborated with Janaki on thousands of songs, beginning with *Anakkili*, his debut film released in 1976. Recalling their long musical association, Ilaiyaraaja described Janaki as



(from left) Bharathiraja and Ilaiyaraaja with S. Janaki.

an exceptionally hard-working artiste. “Just as I strove relentlessly to make the fullest use of every instrument in my compositions, Janaki amma always put in more effort than I expected whenever I taught her a song,” he said. Ilaiyaraaja also noted that she was a gifted composer who had written and composed several devotional bhajans. “Her death is a great loss to Indian film music,” he said. Playback singer P. Susheela paid an emotional tribute to S. Janaki, saying

that no singer in Tamil cinema could match her versatility and expressive voice. In a recorded video message, she said Janaki had rendered innumerable songs of every genre and emotion. **‘No one can match her’** Ms. Susheela said: “There is no one who can match her. Unfortunately, we do not have singers of her calibre today.” Recalling their long association, she said, “We were fortunate to have worked together. Tamil Nadu was blessed by your arrival.” She singled out the song *Singaravelane Deva* as one of Janaki's greatest achievements. “No one else could have rendered *Singaravelane Deva* the way she did. That song took her to the pinnacle of playback singing,” she said. Ms. Susheela said: “May God grant her whatever she desired. I wish she is born again, but perhaps one lifetime is enough.”





**Farewell moment:** Mortal remains of S. Janaki kept at Maharaja's college grounds in Mysuru for public viewing, M.A. SRIRAM

## Music legend Janaki cremated with state honours in Mysuru

**The Hindu Bureau**  
MYSURU

Legendary singer S. Janaki was cremated with state honours at a farmhouse in Kaniyanahundi near Mysuru on Sunday evening.

Janaki's granddaughter Apsara Vidyula performed the last rites as per Telugu Brahmin traditions in the presence of her close relatives, people's representatives, friends, and a large number of admirers and the general public.

Earlier, Janaki's mortal remains were brought in a vehicle with police escort to the farmhouse in H.D. Kote taluk of Mysuru district from Maharaja's College grounds, where it was kept for the public to pay homage. The last rites were held at the farmhouse belonging to Janaki's admirer and caretaker Naveen as per the singer's wishes. Janaki's late husband Ramprasad was from Mysuru and the singer had chosen to make Mysuru her home in the past few

years. Janaki's husband and their only son Murali Krishna had predeceased her.

### 'Unique soul'

Ms. Apsara thanked the government for the state honours and public homage. On Janaki, Ms. Apsara said her grandmother was one of a kind with remarkable talent. "I will remember her more as a grandmother. She was full of love and laughter with a child-like spirit. She was a unique soul," Ms. Apsara said.

Several personalities from the Kannada film industry, including chairperson of the Karnataka Film Chamber of Commerce S. Jaimala, veteran actor Bharathi Vishnuvardhan, and noted music composer Hamsalekha, attended the cremation.

Earlier, Prime Minister Narendra Modi condoled the passing of the veteran singer and said her songs gave voice to every emotion with unparalleled grace as well as versatility.

## Minister slams 'interference' by Kerala HC in temple affairs

No freedom for Devaswom Board to take decisions on Sabarimala as HC is giving instructions even on ritual matters, says K. Muraleedharan; he expresses concern over SIT probe into gold theft case

**The Hindu Bureau**  
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

Devaswom Minister K. Muraleedharan on Sunday slammed the Kerala High Court for "excessive interference" in the affairs of the Sabarimala Ayyappa temple and other temples in the State.

Speaking at a public event, he said the time had come to rethink whether the court should interfere in all such matters, thus limiting the role of the Devaswom Boards and devotees.

Many of the interventions undermined the autonomy of the temples and



K. Muraleedharan expressed concern that the SIT report on the Sabarimala gold theft is yet to be made public. FILE PHOTO

the rights of the believers, he said.

"There is no freedom for the Devaswom Board or the government to take decisions on Sabarimala. The High Court is directly

giving instructions even on ritual matters like which flower to use in temples. It is time for a serious discussion on the extent of the court's intervention in the ritual and administrative

matters of temples," the Minister said.

Mr. Muraleedharan said he had raised the issue in the Assembly. When such opinions were expressed outside the Assembly, he said there was a possibility of contempt of court instead of democratic discussions. Even then, the boards and devotees should stand together, considering the seriousness of the issue. He expressed concern that the report of the Special Investigation Team into the Sabarimala gold theft is yet to see the light of the day. At this rate, the investigation would not be completed anytime soon, he said.

## Govt. to fly bodies of capsized victims to India

**The Hindu Bureau**  
VIJAYAWADA

The bodies of the 15 tourists, who were killed in the accident off Vietnam's Phu Quoc Island, were taken to Ho Chi Minh City on Sunday, from where they will be flown to India soon, the Indian Embassy in Hanoi said.

The Indian mission also said that 16 of the 17 rescued Indian tourists are on their way back home.

The Union government is continuing its efforts to assist the victims' kin, with steps under way to repatriate the remains.

The condition of Gelli Kishore, the survivor from Andhra Pradesh who sustained critical injuries in the accident, remains serious, said officials, forcing doctors to postpone his evacuation.

Ten of the deceased are from Tamil Nadu, three from Andhra Pradesh, and two from Kerala.

The bodies of A.C. Thomas and his wife, Loveni Thomas, the two victims from Kerala, will be brought to the Mumbai airport on Monday around 10 p.m., the Kerala Chief Minister's Office informed.

Officials at the Andhra

**Condition of one survivor from Andhra Pradesh is serious, forcing doctors to put off his evacuation**

Pradesh Bhavan in New Delhi said Union Civil Aviation Minister K. Rammo-han Naidu had intervened to expedite the repatriation of the mortal remains of the three victims from the State.

### Naidu's review

Following details furnished by the respective District

Collectors on the designated recipients, a request was submitted through the e-Care portal for transporting the mortal remains of Nallapeta Adisheshaiah Ravi Teja to Bengaluru, Gelli Jaya Lakshmi to Vijayawada, and Mudi-dium Sreedhar to Chennai.

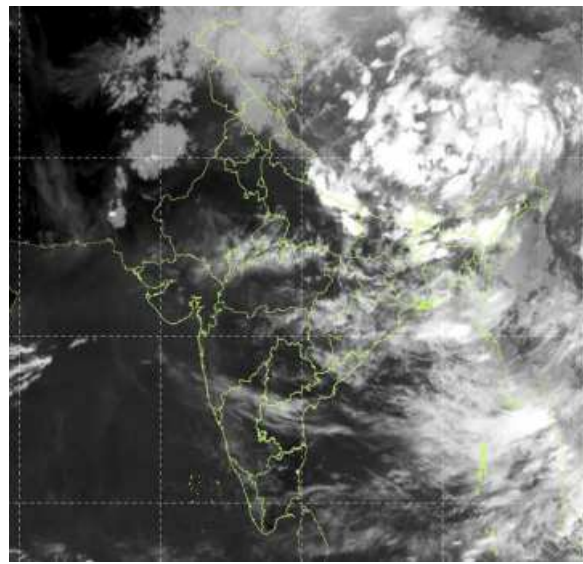
Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N. Chandrababu Naidu reviewed the assistance being extended to the accident victims.

Meanwhile, on Sunday, the Vietnamese police arrested the captain of the speedboat that capsized, authorities said.

(With inputs from agencies)

## WEATHERWATCH

Rainfall, temperature & air quality in select metros yesterday



TEMPERATURE DATA: IMD, POLLUTION DATA: CPCB, MAP: INSAT/IMD (TAKEN AT 17:00 HRS)

**Forecast for Monday:** Heavy Rainfall very likely at isolated places over Arunachal Pradesh, Bihar, East Uttar Pradesh, Gangetic West Bengal, Haryana, Chandigarh. Thunderstorm accompanied with Lightning very likely at isolated places over Arunachal Pradesh, Assam & Meghalaya, Chhattisgarh, East Madhya Pradesh.

| CITY        | RAIN  | MAX   | MIN   | CITY               | RAIN  | MAX   | MIN   |
|-------------|-------|-------|-------|--------------------|-------|-------|-------|
| Agartala    | ..... | 31.6  | 25.0  | Kurnool            | ..... | 36.7  | 26.7  |
| Ahmedabad   | ..... | 37.0  | 27.7  | Lucknow            | ..... | 35.5  | 29.5  |
| Aizawl      | ..... | 29.8  | 19.2  | Madurai            | ..... | 41.0  | 26.6  |
| Bengaluru   | ..... | 32.0  | 21.8  | Mangaluru          | ..... | 2.3   | 30.4  |
| Bhopal      | ..... | 31.4  | 25.4  | Mumbai             | ..... | 32.2  | 27.7  |
| Bhubaneswar | ..... | 35.8  | 25.2  | Mysuru             | ..... | 29.8  | 20.2  |
| Chandigarh  | ..... | 36.1  | 26.2  | New Delhi          | ..... | 36.8  | 28.3  |
| Chennai     | ..... | 38.2  | 28.9  | Patna              | ..... | 0.6   | 35.0  |
| Coimbatore  | ..... | 33.2  | 23.3  | Port Blair         | ..... | 6.7   | 31.2  |
| Dehradun    | ..... | 21.1  | 33.3  | Prayagraj          | ..... | 34.9  | 26.9  |
| Gangtok     | ..... | 25.6  | 19.3  | Puducherry         | ..... | 38.7  | 27.2  |
| Gobindpur   | ..... | 33.3  | 27.0  | Pune               | ..... | 30.5  | 23.7  |
| Guwahati    | ..... | 79    | 33.0  | Raipur             | ..... | 34.7  | 26.4  |
| Hubballi    | ..... | ..... | ..... | Ranchi             | ..... | 30.8  | 23.0  |
| Hyderabad   | ..... | 35.2  | 25.4  | Shillong           | ..... | 23.2  | 18.1  |
| Imphal      | ..... | 1.5   | 30.2  | Shimla             | ..... | 19    | 23.5  |
| Jaipur      | ..... | 35.2  | 27.6  | Srinagar           | ..... | 22.7  | 19.5  |
| Kochi       | ..... | 11    | 31.0  | Thiruvananthapuram | ..... | 32.4  | 25.3  |
| Kohima      | ..... | ..... | ..... | Tiruchirappalli    | ..... | 38.5  | 27.6  |
| Kolkata     | ..... | 0.6   | 25.5  | Vijayawada         | ..... | ..... | ..... |
| Kozhikode   | ..... | 33.5  | 25.8  | Visakhapatnam      | ..... | 33.6  | 28.9  |

(Rainfall data in mm; temperature in Celsius)

| Pollutants in the air you are breathing |                 |                 |     |                   |                  |      | Yesterday |
|-----------------------------------------|-----------------|-----------------|-----|-------------------|------------------|------|-----------|
| CITIES                                  | SO <sub>2</sub> | NO <sub>2</sub> | CO  | PM <sub>2.5</sub> | PM <sub>10</sub> | CODE |           |
| Ahmedabad                               | .....           | 22              | 34  | 23                | .....            | 64   | 100       |
| Bengaluru                               | .....           | 15              | 33  | 61                | .....            | 109  | 109       |
| Chennai                                 | .....           | 5               | 5   | 30                | .....            | 170  | 196       |
| Delhi                                   | .....           | 22              | 46  | 47                | .....            | 201  | 449       |
| Hyderabad                               | .....           | 16              | 12  | 17                | .....            | 44   | 74        |
| Kolkata                                 | .....           | 5               | 35  | 29                | .....            | 90   | 103       |
| Lucknow                                 | .....           | 35              | 12  | 28                | .....            | 49   | 111       |
| Mumbai                                  | .....           | 12              | 100 | 9                 | .....            | 24   | 72        |
| Pune                                    | .....           | 54              | 24  | 42                | .....            | 42   | 78        |
| Visakhapatnam                           | .....           | 30              | 73  | 20                | .....            | 69   | 144       |

In observation made at 4.00 p.m., Greater Noida, Uttar Pradesh recorded an overall  quality index (AQI) score of 335 indicating an unhealthy level of pollution. In contrast, Aizawl, Mizoram recorded a healthy AQI score of 15.

Air Quality Code: ■ Poor ■ Moderate ■ Good (Readings indicate average AQI)

**SO<sub>2</sub>:** Sulphur Dioxide. Short-term exposure can harm the respiratory system, making breathing difficult. It can affect visibility by reacting with other air particles to form haze and stain culturally important objects such as statues and monuments.

**NO<sub>2</sub>:** Nitrogen Dioxide. Aggravates respiratory illness, causes haze to form by reacting with other air particles, causes acid rain, pollutes coastal waters.

**CO:** Carbon monoxide. High concentration in air reduces oxygen supply to critical organs like the heart and brain. At very high levels, it can cause dizziness, confusion, unconsciousness and even death.

**PM<sub>2.5</sub> & PM<sub>10</sub>:** Particulate matter pollution can cause irritation of the eyes, nose and throat, coughing, chest tightness and shortness of breath, reduced lung function, irregular heartbeat, asthma attacks, heart attacks and premature death in people with heart or lung disease

## Leopard seen near Tirumala walking path; surveillance stepped up

**The Hindu Bureau**  
VIJAYAWADA

Andhra Pradesh Deputy Chief Minister and Minister for Environment and Forests K. Pawan Kalyan has asked officials to take steps for the safety of devotees using the Tirumala footpath, after a leopard was found roaming near Dorasani Mandapam.

A press release said Mr. Pawan Kalyan had directed that H.A.N.U.M.A.N (Healing and Nurturing Units for Monitoring, Aid and Nursing of Wildlife) teams be deployed to ensure the wild cat caused no harm to the devotees.

### 'Move in groups'

He asked the Forest Department and the Tirumala Tirupati Devasthanams's (TTD) forest and vigilance wings to coordinate properly so that the devotees would be safe, and advised that they move in groups.

The Deputy Chief Minister advised officials to take appropriate measures to ensure that pilgrims were not disturbed. Officials explained to the Deputy Chief Minister the measures being taken, in coordination with the Forest Department, the TTD Forest Wing and the TTD Vigilance Wing, to ensure pilgrim safety.

Mr. Kalyan asked officials to alert the pilgrims and clear dense thickets in sensitive areas. He stressed the need for adequate security measures to allay fears of pilgrims.

The big cat was spotted near the Lord Narasimha Swamy temple, about half-way along the Alipiri footpath.

## Karnataka urges Kerala to donate elephant to Mookambika temple

**K.S. Sudhi**  
KOCHI

The Kerala Forest Department is facing increased pressure to donate or facilitate the transfer of captive elephants to neighbouring States.

Karnataka Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar has written to his Kerala counterpart, V.D. Satheesan, to facilitate "the donation of a female elephant from any willing temple in Kerala" to the Kollur Mookambika Temple in Karnataka, to "participate in religious ceremonies and temple rituals".

Mr. Shivakumar has sought the help of Mr. Satheesan in facilitating the do-



Kerala has around 30 captive elephants in government-run camps across the State. R.K. NITHIN

nation in "compliance with all applicable statutory provisions, rules" as he felt that the "noble gesture would further strengthen the centuries-old spiritual

and cultural relationship" between the two States.

Earlier, a request from the Telangana Chief Minister seeking camp elephants - pachyderms res-

cued and maintained in the State's camp facilities - was turned down by the Kerala government, according to forest officials.

Kerala has around 30 captive elephants in camps, including at Kottor, Dhoni, Malayattoor, and Konni.

The captive elephant population of Kerala is estimated at 368.

Inter-State transfers can be permitted only in cases of elephants with ownership certificates issued before February 24, 2024, and their genetic profile entered in the electronic monitoring application of the Union Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change.

## After Minister's incognito bus ride, Bengaluru rolls out passenger-friendly reforms

**The Hindu Bureau**  
BENGALURU

The Bengaluru Metropolitan Transport Corporation (BMTCC) has issued a fresh set of directives to its staff to improve passenger service and safety, following a surprise late-night bus inspection by Transport Minister Byrathi Suresh on Saturday.

The Minister travelled incognito, wearing a face mask, on over 10 BMTCC buses across Bengaluru to assess the service.

### Orders suspension

During the inspection, he found a conductor and a driver allegedly derelict in

**Conductor asks Minister to get down after the latter did not give exact change for two tickets**

their duties and recommended their suspension. A BMTCC source told *The Hindu* that an inquiry had been ordered against the said staff members and immediate action initiated.

The Minister had boarded a bus travelling from Hebbal towards Nagashettilalli on Saturday night and asked the conductor to issue two tickets after handing over a ₹100 note. The conductor showed his

bag, saying he did not have change, and asked the Minister to get off the bus if he could not give exact change.

The Minister also found that a bus driver did not halt at a stop, despite a waiting passenger signalling the driver.

Following the inspection, the BMTCC directed its drivers to halt buses at designated stops. Drivers and conductors should treat passengers with respect. Conductors should encourage commuters to use the QR code-based UPI payment facility. No passenger should be forced to alight for lack of change, it said.

## Drones move TB samples, cut diagnosis costs from ₹9,451 to ₹91 in new ICMR trial

**Siddharth Kumar Singh**  
HYDERABAD

A drone flight costing patients almost nothing could replace journeys that once left suspected tuberculosis (TB) patients spending an average of ₹9,451 out of their own pockets. A study by the All India Institute of Medical Sciences, Bibinagar, in Telangana has found that transporting sputum samples by drone reduced patients' average expenditure to just ₹91 while cutting diagnosis time from 15 days to five days.

The study, published in the *International Journal of Tuberculosis and Lung Disease* evaluated the impact of using drones to transport sputum samples



The drone programme aims to streamline the transport of sputum samples from PHCs in remote areas to testing facilities. FILE PHOTO

from remote villages to TB testing centres in Yadadri Bhuvanagiri district under the Indian Council of Medical Research's (ICMR) i-DRONE initiative. The study analysed data from 840 participants.

Before the intervention,

**Emergency workers recovered the body of one more person from Himachal Pradesh**

disaster.

Officials said that with the recovery of his body, all missing people had now been accounted for.

After his relatives identified the body, it was shifted to the Vythiri Taluk Hospital for post-mortem examination.

Following the procedure, it will be shifted to the Kozhikode Government Medical College Hospital for embalming.

## SI booked for letting six-year-old drive a car

**The Hindu Bureau**  
HYDERABAD

A Hyderabad Police Sub-Inspector has been booked after allowing his six-year-old granddaughter to drive a car on a busy road in Narsingi, with the officer claiming he was preparing her for a Guinness World Records attempt as the world's youngest driver.

The incident, which was reported on Saturday, came to light after a video showing the child behind the wheel while the officer occupied the front passenger seat went viral on social media platforms. A case has been registered against the officer.

only needed to visit their nearest PHC or subcentre, where trained healthcare workers collected and securely packaged sputum samples before drones transported them to the designated TB facilities.

The average out-of-pocket expenditure for patients, including medical expenses, travel, food and wage loss for both patients and attendants, dropped from ₹9,451 to ₹90.9. The intervention also improved reporting times. Before drones were introduced, over 92% of patients waited more than two days to receive their test results.

During the drone phase, 76.3% received results the next day, while only 16.3% experienced delays beyond two days.





Oil conundrum  
India's energy imports from Russia seem driven by confusion, not strategy

Union Ministry of Commerce and Industry (MCI) data on India's May crude imports show that receipts from Russia had reached the pre-sanction levels of more than 40%, which is also the highest in two years. Though India has defended this as commercially prudent, its yuan-based payments give China an edge to internationalise its currency at India's expense, even if it has no bearing on the domestic strength of the Indian rupee due to strict capital controls. Oil import concentration from a single source, and paying a premium, is risky for India, which has long pursued a diversified energy strategy. Moreover, sourcing fuel from the Gulf spot market amid evolving sanctions has its own risks. Secondary sanctions could hit trade channels, exposing Indian refiners to severe supply shocks. India's crude imports from Russia surged in June, while UAE shipments were at record levels as refiners sought to secure supplies after the Strait of Hormuz reopened. However, renewed Iran-U.S. hostilities have put those flows at risk. And even as Venezuela has emerged as a key supplier, increasing and unsustainably high one-country concentration could weaken India's bargaining power, reduce flexibility, and erode its credibility as an independent balancing power.

MCI data highlight the price impact: Russian imports carried a \$46-per-ton premium. Import value surged 83% amid a 2% fall in volume, likely diminishing Indian refiners' margins on refined products using Russian crude. While spot purchases have enabled refiners to capture discounts of up to \$10 per barrel on Russian Urals crude relative to Brent during some periods, after February this year, narrowing discounts, weaker product cracks, and geopolitical risks have moderated gross refining margins. India must strike a balance between having long-term stable contracts with multiple producers, and selectively using the spot-market to mitigate the procurement risks. Until the Russia-Ukraine conflict, nearly 70% of India's crude imports came through long-term contracts, particularly from West Asia. True, India cannot overlook the diplomatic costs as Russian energy dependence risks sanctions. When Russian crude was cheap because of discounts on account of the Ukraine war, India reduced imports under U.S. pressure; now when it is being sold at a premium because of the Iran war, India is moving back to Russian crude. India must expand its strategic petroleum reserves to cushion temporary disruptions. Whether it increases or cuts down Russian oil imports, India seems to make decisions that are far removed from any sense of strategic autonomy.

Insular incentive  
Ethanol-blended fuel should not be forced on consumers irrationally

The Indian government's policy to continue producing E20 petrol at a cost higher than that of pure petrol when oil prices dip under \$70 a barrel to "compensate farmers adequately" is a deceptively well-formulated proposition. Most feedstock for the fuel-blending programme is from sugarcane, one of India's most water- and fertilizer-intensive crops, mainly grown in water-stressed Maharashtra and Karnataka. Whether the policy's net economic benefit remains positive will depend on the gains from lower crude imports, environmental improvements, and higher rural incomes outweighing these additional costs. Efficiency also remains a concern. Consumers – including people who are poorer than sugarcane farmers – pay more at the pump, oil marketing companies procure ethanol at the administered price, distilleries buy feedstock, and only then do farmers receive higher prices. Higher feedstock prices also do not address most reasons farmers have lower incomes, such as post-harvest losses and limited market access. Crucially, if the government rewards every unit of ethanol irrespective of feedstock, the policy will favour whichever feedstock has the largest installed base: sugarcane. Instead, the objectives should include resource efficiency and food security. The state could invest in irrigation and logistics and institute revenue-sharing arrangements with ethanol producers and cooperatives.

India has encouraged maize and grain-based distillation capacity has expanded rapidly, periodically allowed ethanol to be produced from the Food Corporation's surplus or damaged rice holdings, and has supported commercial plants using agricultural residues such as rice straw under Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas schemes. Maize and millets are less thirsty but maize still demands significant fertilizer inputs while millets produce less fermentable starch per hectare. Sweet sorghum is less water-intensive and has a shorter growing season than sugarcane. Lignocellulosic biomass such as rice and wheat straw, maize stover and groundnut shells can also support second-generation (2G) ethanol. 2G ethanol from agricultural residues can avoid using cropland for fuel, reducing competition with food crops and addressing stubble burning. It is more expensive and technologically demanding but that is a better problem to solve, with proactive policymaking. The government could pay a premium for ethanol produced from residues, subsidise equipment and infrastructure to collect and store crop residue, facilitate contracts between aggregators and distilleries, and provide viability-gap funding and offtake agreements. Ultimately, ethanol policy should not be independent of agricultural policy. And import substitution is no excuse for consumers being forced to pay more for lower-mileage fuel than pure petrol.

Five crore Indians wait when the courts take a break

The Supreme Court of India and the major High Courts are on a summer holiday break, i.e., shut down with some vacation Benches functioning to hear urgent matters. However, shops, markets, eating places, government and private offices, hospitals and police stations do not cease to work even though their staff enjoy personal leave. On the other hand, somewhere in an Indian jail tonight, a man who has been convicted of nothing is finishing another year behind bars, his trial still ongoing and perhaps years away from ending. He is one of the roughly three in four prisoners in this country who are undertrials: unconvicted, presumed innocent, yet serving time anyway – often longer than the sentence they would have received had they pleaded guilty. And as you read this, the courts, the public institutions that hold the fate of the poor in their hands, are functioning at only a fraction of their strength.

**A three-century backlog**  
From June 1 to July 12, the Supreme Court is on its summer break, sitting with three or four Benches a week instead of a full court and resuming in earnest on July 13. The doors are not bolted; urgent pleas are still heard. But for six weeks, the most powerful court in the world's most populous democracy idles.

Now hold that against the number it is meant to be fighting. As of the last day of 2025, more than 5.39 crore cases were pending in Indian courts: over 4.76 crore in the district courts, 63.6 lakh in the High Courts, and more than 92,000 in the Supreme Court itself, its heaviest load in over 30 years. A government study once calculated that, at the present pace, clearing the pile could take three centuries.

Three centuries. And the Court takes the summer and winter vacations off. To be fair, the judges deserve it. The recess is when reserved judgments finally get written, when the brutal daily cause-list eases enough to think.



Vijay L. Kelkar  
Vice-Chairman of the Pune International Centre



Pradeep S. Mehta  
Secretary-General of CUTS International (Consumer Unity and Trust Society)

When courts rest together for vacations, crores of litigants across the country wait longer for justice

Last year the Chief Justice of India and his four senior-most colleagues worked clean through the first week of the break. Indian judges are among the most overworked in the world. This is not an accusation of laziness; no one who has seen a judge's docket could make one.

Because that is precisely the point. When the people doing the work are exhausted and the backlog is biblical, what conceivable logic shuts the whole shop at once? Not that judges rest – which they should – but that almost all of them rest together, so the institution goes quiet for six-plus weeks every year. And the habit is a colonial hand-me-down: the calendar was built for English judges who could not stand the Indian heat and retreated to cooler climes each summer, then enjoyed long Christmas holidays in the winter.

In 2024, the Court announced a fix: it renamed the "summer vacation" as "partial court working days". That was it. The number of days it actually sits – about 190 days in a year – did not change. You cannot rebrand your way out of a backlog; a litigant whose case is stuck does not care what the recess is called, only whether his matter is heard and disposed of.

**Justice needs court continuity**  
So what would actually help? The first answer is one the judiciary's own watchdogs have urged for years: do not abolish judicial rest; stagger it. A parliamentary standing committee in 2023 objected to "the entire court going on vacation en masse", and proposed the obvious: rotate the leave, keep the Benches full, and never let the court run thin. A hospital does not empty its wards because its doctors are owed time off; it builds a roster. The Law Commission and the Justice Malimath Committee said the same, long ago. They were not enemies of the courts; they were trying to save them from themselves.

The standard objection is that all this is a sideshow: the real disease is vacancies, not vacations. It is true that courts are starved of judges, with up to a third of High Court seats

lying empty. But the objection boomerangs. If the Bench is already running at half strength, thinning it further for six weeks every summer is not a defence of the recess; it is the strongest case against it. And while filling those seats depends on the government and the collegium and will drag on for years, the calendar is the judiciary's to fix. One reform needs permission; the other needs only will.

**Beyond courts, towards solutions**  
Staggering the leave, though, only treats the symptom. The deeper fix is to keep disputes out of the courtroom in the first place; it was never meant to be the first stop for every quarrel, but the last. India already has the tools. Lok Adalats settled more than 2.59 crore cases in a single national sitting last December, and over 23.5 crore in three years. The Mediation Act of 2023 now nudges parties to attempt settlement before going to court, and arbitration can take commercial disputes entirely out of judges' hands; yet these routes remain badly underused. But none of this happens on its own.

The country has a reservoir of experience it scarcely draws on: its retired judges, who spent their careers mastering this very machinery and step down, still in full command of it, at 62 or 65. Their expertise need not retire with them. Albeit many of them do function as heads of quasi-judicial bodies and tribunals. Freed from any daily docket, a dedicated corps of former judges could be invited to take up a single targeted charge: identify where cases pile up, set public targets for their disposal, and account for progress openly. Reform that belongs to everyone belongs to no one.

The judges will keep working through the heat, as they always do. The honest demand is not that they stop resting, but that the courts stop closing ranks and falling silent at the same moment, because justice, for five crore Indians, is not on vacation. It is overdue.

With contributions from Anushka Kewlani of CUTS

The making of Israel's retreat into isolation

The primary justification for the creation of Israel was that Europeans of Jewish origin persecuted and ghettoised, deserve their own state where they can live like other "normal" nations. For much of its history, Israel sought to escape the isolation that marked Jewish existence in Europe before the creation of the Jewish state. One of its goals was to transform Israel from a besieged regional outlier into an increasingly accepted member of the West Asian political order, a goal made very difficult if not impossible because of the expulsion of almost two-thirds of the Palestinian population from the territory that became Israel. However, through peace treaties with Egypt and Jordan, quiet understandings with Gulf monarchies, and ultimately the Abraham Accords, Israel appeared to have broken out of its strategic ghetto.

**A war's global fallout**  
Now, Israel seems determined to reverse that achievement. Through the unrestrained exercise of military power in Gaza, Lebanon, Syria, and Iran, and through its relentless expansion of settlements in the West Bank, it is steadily recreating the very isolation from which it once sought to escape. The result is a country that is militarily stronger than ever but politically more isolated than at any time in recent decades.

The principal cause of this growing isolation is the belief among Israel's current leadership that military superiority can substitute for political strategy. The devastation of Gaza has become the defining symbol of this approach. What began as a response to the Hamas attacks of October 7, 2023, evolved into a campaign that much of the world views as collective punishment on a massive scale. Images of destroyed neighbourhoods, displaced populations, and mounting civilian casualties have profoundly altered global perceptions of Israel.

Israel's actions in Iran and Lebanon have reinforced this trend. The repeated resort to military force beyond its borders reflects a



Mohammed Ayoob  
University Distinguished Professor Emeritus of International Relations, Michigan State University, and the author most recently of 'From Regional Security to Global IR' (2024)

Israel's isolation is no longer imposed; it is increasingly self-inflicted

doctrine that prioritises immediate tactical gains over long-term strategic consequences. While Israel has demonstrated impressive military capabilities, its attacks have also intensified regional instability and generated resentment among states that are forced to absorb the political and economic consequences of escalating conflict.

This is particularly evident in the Gulf. The Abraham Accords were founded on a convergence of interests among Israel and several Arab states. Economic cooperation, technological exchange and a shared security concern about Iran created a basis for normalisation. But the success of the Accords depended on an implicit assumption that Israel would act with sufficient restraint to make continued cooperation politically sustainable for Arab governments.

That assumption has been severely undermined. The destruction of Gaza and the ethnic cleansing of much of its population has generated enormous anger across Arab societies. Israel's attacks on Iran have further complicated matters by exposing Gulf states to risks that they never sought. These states may share concerns about Iranian influence, but they do not wish to become collateral victims of Israeli military adventures. The result is a growing gap between the strategic calculations of Gulf rulers and Israeli priorities.

**An alliance under strain**  
The deterioration of Israel's relationship with the United States is even more significant. Washington increasingly finds itself paying the diplomatic and economic costs of Israeli actions while exercising limited influence over Israeli decision-making.

Recent tensions surrounding the U.S.-Iran memorandum illustrate this dynamic. Reports of sharp exchanges between Washington and Jerusalem over the agreement culminated in United States Vice-President J.D. Vance's unusually blunt rebuke of Israeli criticism.

"Donald J. Trump is the only head of state in the entire world who is sympathetic to the nation of Israel at this moment in time," Mr. Vance declared, adding that if he were a member of the Israeli cabinet, he might not be attacking "the only powerful ally that I have anywhere left in the entire world".

The significance of the remark lay not merely in its criticism of the Benjamin Netanyahu government but in its clear acknowledgment of Israel's international isolation. The dispute is not merely about Iran. It reflects a deeper concern within the U.S. administration that Israeli policies are complicating broader American strategic objectives in West Asia. The widening daylight between the two allies does not mean that the partnership is ending, but it does indicate that unconditional American support can no longer be taken for granted.

**The return of isolation**  
Perhaps the most self-defeating aspect of Israel's current trajectory is its policy in the West Bank. Settlement expansion has accelerated to the point where the territorial basis for a viable Palestinian state has disappeared. Simultaneously, attacks by Jewish settlers against Palestinian communities have become increasingly frequent. Reports that such actions often occur with the protection or acquiescence of elements within the Israeli security forces have further eroded Israel's international legitimacy.

By making a two-state solution impossible, Israel is replacing a political problem with a permanent system of domination that much of the world finds morally and politically reprehensible.

History offers a striking irony. Zionism sought to ensure that the Jewish people would never again live isolated behind walls of fear and hostility as they did in Europe. But contemporary Israeli policies risk producing a modern version of that condition. The difference is that this isolation is no longer imposed; it is self-inflicted.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Strengthening ties

The strategic partnership between India and New Zealand can prove beneficial for both countries, especially as global uncertainty rises due to the West Asia conflict. Strengthening ties with major economies is vital for India, particularly as the U.S.'s reliability as an ally has come under question. However, the government must ensure that exports outpace imports to maintain a strong and stable balance of payments.  
**Aanya Singhal,**  
Noida, Uttar Pradesh

S. Janaki

The passing of S. Janaki marks the poignant end of a golden era in Indian cinema. For over six decades, her versatile voice was the raw, emotional pulse of our everyday lives,

dominating South Indian cinema with an unmatched range. Whether delivering complex classical masterpieces such as "*Singaravelane Deva*" (*Konjum Salangai*), playful comic numbers, or shifting her vocal modulation to effortlessly sing in a child's voice, she was the undisputed queen of expression. What truly elevated Janaki Amma to an icon was her ability to dissolve linguistic boundaries. She never needed a government title; her listeners had already crowned her. The nightingale has fallen silent, but her staggering treasury of songs will comfort us for centuries to come.  
**S. Padmanabhan,**  
Kochi, Kerala

Janaki Amma's mastery of the nuances of singing

made her one of the most sought-after playback singers, and she dominated the Indian music world for several decades by rendering memorable songs not only in many Indian languages but also in foreign languages. Janaki Amma, who rightly earned the sobriquet "Nightingale of the South", leaves behind a priceless legacy for us to cherish, enjoy, and remember her by forever.  
**Tharcius S. Fernando,**  
Chennai

As someone who grew up listening to her innumerable songs, I will always savour and cherish her timeless gems, especially "*Chinna Chinna Vanna Kuyil*" (*Mouna Ragam*), "*Machaanai Paatheengala*" (*Annakili*), and "*Senthoora Poove*" (*16 Vayathinile*). The legendary singer

demonstrated that music is a divine unifier that transcends all man-made barriers and divisions.  
**B. Suresh Kumar,**  
Coimbatore

The loss of Janaki Amma stirs profound grief in hearts across India. For generations of listeners, there is a Janaki Amma song in the playlist, for every mood and occasion. Reducing her legacy to the 'Nightingale of South India' seems a disservice, especially in a country as vast and culturally diverse as India.  
**Lakshmi K.S.,**  
Kochi

Her voice lent emotional depth to thousands of songs across Indian cinema while remaining remarkable for its simplicity and expressive power. Her

legacy will endure not only through her vast body of work but also through the timeless emotions her songs continue to evoke.  
**Maliha Fatima,**  
Hyderabad

Though S. Janaki sang innumerable songs and won plenty of awards, "*Singaravelane Deva*" remains a watermark in her outstanding career. The song, set in raga *Abheri*, is the eternal favourite, tugging at the heartstrings of young and old, transcending time and age boundaries. At a time when song tracks are recorded separately and later synthesised, this immortal composition was a pioneer of the technique. S. Janaki's vocals and the nadaswaram performance of Karukurichi Arunachalam were recorded separately and blended

together later. The breathtaking exchange, in which her voice matched the complex, rapid notes of the nadaswaram note by note, catapulted her to overnight fame.  
**R. Sivakumar,**  
Chennai

The passing of South India's Nightingale, feels like the quiet fading of a voice that cradled our childhoods, gave language to our heartbreaks, and brought a gentle, divine warmth into our homes for over six decades. While we mourn the loss of an icon whose humility was as immense as her talent, we take comfort in knowing that her songs are immortal.  
**Kshirasagara Balaji Rao,**  
Hyderabad

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.



# Judging graduates, not entrance scores

Few institutions in India carry the popularity of the IITs. Getting into them requires intense preparation and intellectual discipline. JEE ranks and GATE scores used for admissions to India’s premier institutions are, therefore, important. Recruiters, too, have often treated them as an indication of a student’s ability. Recently, however, the All IITs Placement Committee has decided to exclude JEE ranks, GATE scores, percentiles, and other such credentials from standard placement resumes. Even if some consider it unnecessary, this decision deserves wide support.

**Beyond entrance ranks**  
An entrance examination captures a snapshot of a student’s performance on a single day. A degree reflects years of learning. Between the two lie classrooms, laboratories, projects, internships, peer learning, teamwork, participation in various extended curricular activities, failures, recoveries and personal growth. If campus recruitment continues to privilege entrance rank, it quietly reduces the IIT experience as a whole to an interlude between JEE and employment. That is unfair to the student and to the institution.

To treat a student’s entrance rank as permanent proof of ability is a constricted view. A more serious view examines whether a student has solved problems, completed meaningful projects, worked in teams, built prototypes, written code, contributed to research, communicated clearly and shown the maturity required in the workplace. Preparing oneself for work requires competence and a willingness to be a lifelong learner. It does not rely on the entrance test score alone.

The Committee’s decision is also consistent with the National Education Policy (NEP 2020), which emphasises the need to move beyond an examination-dominated system. The policy asks us to focus on



**Mamidala Jagadesh Kumar**  
Chairman, Review Committee for NEP 2020, Ministry of Education, GoI and former Vice-Chancellor, JNU and former Chairman, UGC. Views are personal

Removing entrance ranks from standard resumes prevents a potentially prejudicial and often irrelevant data point from becoming a default filter

creating an ecosystem that enables students to develop critical thinking, creativity, ethical judgment, problem-solving, and holistic development. If our higher education institutions are expected to provide these capabilities to our students, why shouldn’t placement systems recognise them?

There could be another, more sensitive reason for the decision. It could be possible to infer social category or admission route from entrance ranks by comparing programme-level opening and closing ranks. Such inference may not always be explicit, but it can influence perception. What recruiters should be looking for is not how the student entered IIT, but what the student can do now.

Both public institutions and recruiters play important roles in designing hiring processes that reduce avoidable bias. Removing entrance ranks from standard resumes prevents a potentially prejudicial and often irrelevant data point from becoming a default filter. Some may say that recruiters need filters. Nobody is contesting that need. But employers already have better instruments. They use CGPA or CPI thresholds, technical interviews, coding tests, case discussions, design tasks, project reviews, research work, communication abilities and behavioural assessments. It has long been recognised that JEE or GATE scores do not reliably capture these.

A student’s entrance rank may say something about past preparation. It cannot say enough about future contributions. With enhanced access, our higher education institutions attract many first-generation learners, rural students, non-English-medium students, and those from economically disadvantaged backgrounds. Some may take time to adjust to the new environment. Many grow substantially during their IIT years. A fair placement process should, therefore, allow them to

present what they have achieved years after obtaining their entrance scores.

Student well-being should be our top priority. If recruiting methods make ranks part of students’ identities, they become a burden for many students. When the recruitment process turns ranks into hierarchies, students can experience anxiety and comparison. IITs are places where students grow beyond the circumstances of entry. Then why can’t our placement system let students know that the work they do after admission matters, not their ranks?

This does not mean that entrance examinations are unimportant. But the selection process for admission and the selection process for recruitment are different altogether. The first decides entry into an academic programme. The second should judge current professional readiness. Confusing the two weakens both.

The decision to move away from publicising only the highest salary packages also deserves attention. Highest packages create headlines. They may lead students and parents to believe that high packages are normal, when in reality they are often outliers. Median salary is a better representative measure to get an overall sense of how the larger graduating cohort has fared. It is important to encourage a more mature public conversation on employment by emphasising median salaries.

**A better signal**  
Together, these decisions show welcome institutional seriousness. They recognise that campus recruitment must assess students for what they have learnt and become during their time at the institution. A fair placement system should not allow an old rank to overshadow evidence of a student’s present competence and readiness for work. Other higher education institutions would do well to draw from this example.

# A.P. and the next El Niño challenge

Heatwaves and rainfall deficits could put the State’s preparedness to the test

## STATE OF PLAY

**Nellore Sravani**

Much before El Niño formed over the Pacific Ocean, Andhra Pradesh got a bitter taste of what was to come. In May, the State experienced oppressive heat, unending warm nights, and intense heatwaves. Cities and towns wore a deserted look as daytime temperatures remained above 44 degrees Celsius for nine consecutive days, with the season’s highest touching 48.3 degrees Celsius.

In addition to bringing back unpleasant memories of the previous El Niño events in the State, the record-breaking temperatures heralded a disturbing weather pattern, marked by scanty rainfall and more heatwaves. Even on July 12, the India Meteorological Department (IMD), Amaravati, issued heatwave alerts for the State.

This is the third time in 10 years that the State’s preparedness is being put to the test, the first two being 2015 and 2023. In 2015, which witnessed a strong El Niño event, heatwaves killed at least 2,300 people in the country, with Andhra Pradesh alone accounting for 1,369 deaths, forcing the government to form the Andhra Pradesh State Disaster Management Authority (APSDMA).

Weather experts say that whenever sea surface temperatures in the Pacific Ocean rise beyond 2 degrees Celsius, meteorologists declare it a “very strong” El Niño event. Between 1951 and 2025, this threshold was crossed four times – 1972,1982, 2015 and 2023 – according to IMD experts.

Meteorologists believe there is a high likelihood of



another strong El Niño event this year.

**A testing monsoon**  
For Andhra Pradesh, an overall below-normal monsoon has been forecast, with isolated areas showing the probability of receiving normal or above-normal rainfall, which indicates the likelihood of the formation of low-pressure systems in the Bay of Bengal. But this is only a possibility.

The State receives most of its rainfall during the Southwest monsoon, particularly in August and September, when El Niño is expected to gain strength. While the State received about normal rainfall in June, as predicted, July has begun on a slightly dry note.

According to the Directorate of Economics and Statistics, the State received 86.2 mm of rainfall against the normal 149.1 mm between June 1 and July 11, recording a deficit of 42.2%. Except for two districts that reported normal rainfall, 26 of the 28 districts have reported either deficient or largely deficient rainfall, presenting a bleak picture.

The State’s long-period average annual rainfall is 858 mm, but this year’s total is projected at 690 mm, which means a deviation of around 20%, which, again, is double the deviations recorded in the State in recent El Niño years. According to the APSDMA, negative deviations in recent El Niño years ranged between

4% and 11%.

The immediate impact of deficit rainfall is on the farming community and agricultural activities. In 2023, 54 mandals were declared drought-hit, while at least 6.96 lakh farmers suffered losses in 103 of the State’s 688 mandals.

The government has begun preparations.

At a review meeting, Andhra Pradesh Home and Disaster Management Minister V. Anitha stressed the need to disseminate weather information down to the village level to minimise crop losses. But, there is a challenge: the agricultural department issues alerts and advisories to farmers based on the agroclimatic zones. Academicians have flagged the haphazard clubbing of areas with zones of different characteristics. This can lead to a mismatch in the advisory being given and the ground reality of farmers. The government’s objective cannot be achieved unless the structural issues are addressed.

The agricultural department has begun alerting farmers about shifting to drought-hardy crops in rain-fed areas of Rayalaseema to tide over the crisis. But questions have also been raised about the willingness of farmers to shift to these crops.

The State appears to have learnt from the lessons of 2015 by significantly reducing heat-stroke deaths. In 2023, the number of deaths recorded had drastically come down to three. But ensuring that timely weather advisories reach farmers remains a weak link.

It is to be seen whether the government’s preparedness remains only on paper or aids in mitigating the impact of the global event.

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# Disproportionate SIR deletions in Manipur’s tribal constituencies

Despite accounting for only 37.8% of the electorate, the ST constituencies accounted for 64.2% of deletions during the enumeration phase of the SIR

## DATA POINT

**Pon Vasanth B.A. Nitika Francis**

An analysis of deletions during the enumeration phase of the ongoing special intensive revision (SIR) of Manipur’s electoral rolls showed that the 19 constituencies reserved for Scheduled Tribes (ST) saw disproportionately high deletions compared with the remaining 41 Assembly constituencies (ACs) (**Chart 1**).

The draft SIR rolls, released on July 5, showed that these 19 ACs in the hill areas – which have a predominant presence of the Kuki-Zo and Naga communities – accounted for 64.2% of the 1.59 lakh deletions, despite accounting for only 37.8% of the 20.93 lakh voters present on the State’s rolls before SIR.

As **Table 2** shows, the share of voters from ST constituencies in Manipur’s electorate dropped by 2.1 percentage points due to disproportionately high deletions in those ACs.

Manipur has been in turmoil ever since ethnic violence erupted in May 2023. Among the ST ACs, deletions were more concentrated in and around Churachandpur – a district with a significant presence of the Kuki-Zo community, which was the epicentre of the conflict (**Map 1**).

In the ST constituencies, 76.1% of deletions were recorded as “Permanently Shifted”, compared with 53.9% in the General ACs. Meanwhile, “Death” accounted for 41.9% of deletions in the General ACs, in contrast to just 18.9% in the ST ACs.

More women got deleted than men. More than 8% of female voters were deleted compared with 6% of male voters. For every 1,000 male voters deleted, 1,271 female voters were deleted, bringing the gender ratio in the rolls down from 1,071 before SIR to 1,057 in the draft rolls. In 18 ACs, 60% to 69% of the deletions were women.



**Vote in question:** Voters at polling station in Kangpokpi in Manipur during 2022 Assembly polls

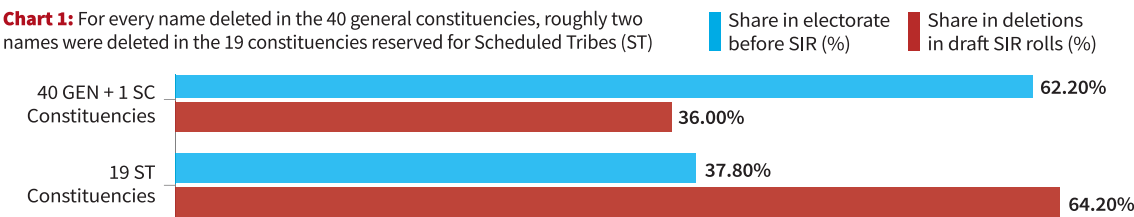
**Table 1:** The share of voters from ST constituencies in Manipur’s electorate dropped by 2.1 percentage points

|                                      | GEN - ACs (40) | ST - ACs (19) | SC - ACs (1) | Total (60) |
|--------------------------------------|----------------|---------------|--------------|------------|
| Electorates before SIR               | 12,69,503      | 7,91,859      | 31,714       | 20,93,076  |
| Share in electorate before SIR - (A) | 60.7%          | 37.8%         | 1.5%         | 100%       |
| Deletions                            | 55,460         | 1,01,827      | 1,390        | 1,58,677   |
| % Deleted                            | 4.4%           | 12.9%         | 4.4%         | 7.6%       |
| Share in total deletions             | 35%            | 64.2%         | 0.9%         | 100%       |
| Electorates in draft SIR rolls       | 12,14,043      | 6,90,032      | 30,324       | 19,34,399  |
| Share in draft SIR rolls - (B)       | 62.8%          | 35.7%         | 1.6%         | 100%       |
| Change between A and B (% points)    | (+) 2.1        | (-) 2.1       | (+) 0.1      |            |

## Disenfranchisement risk

The data were sourced from the lists of deletions published by the *Chief Electoral Officer, Manipur*

**Chart 1:** For every name deleted in the 40 general constituencies, roughly two names were deleted in the 19 constituencies reserved for Scheduled Tribes (ST)



**1** Three of the four ACs with the highest deletions (%) were in Churachandpur district

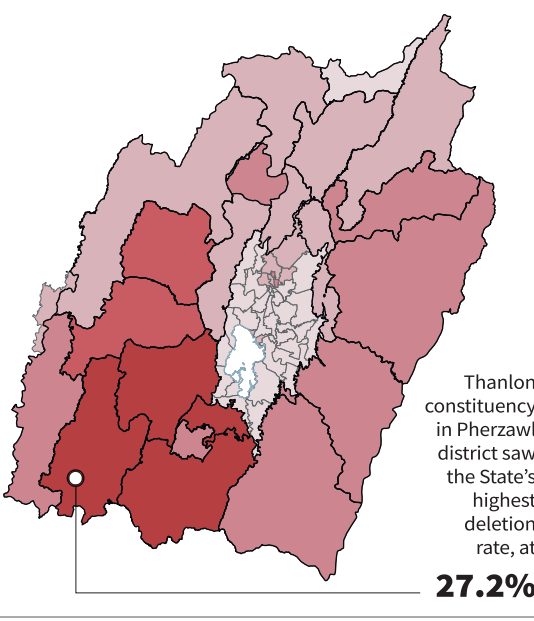
**2** More than half of total deletions came from just 12 ST seats

Scan for the full article with insights from academic Khom Khan Suan Hausing and Gautam Mukhopadhyaya, a former Ambassador of India

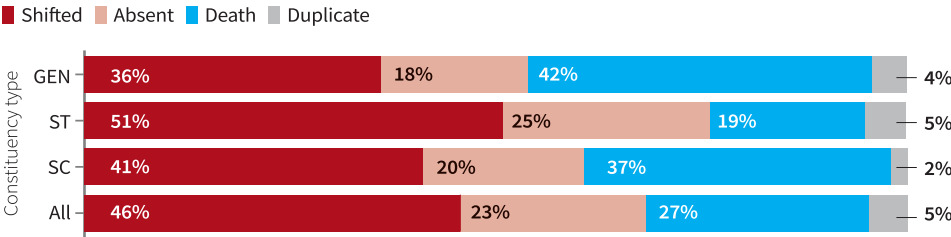
**Map:** Deletions were more concentrated in and around Churachandpur district, which has a significant presence of the Kuki-Zo community and was the epicentre of the conflict

The unshaded region in the centre of the map is the Loktak lake

Under 5% 5–10% 10–15% 15–20% 20% & above



**Chart 2:** The chart shows shares of different reasons for which names were deleted in different types of constituencies



**Table 2:** The table below shows the reason-wise deletions in different types of constituencies

| Constituency type | Shifted | Absent | Death  | Duplicate | Total Deletions |
|-------------------|---------|--------|--------|-----------|-----------------|
| GEN (40)          | 20,032  | 9,861  | 23,227 | 2,340     | 55,460          |
| ST (19)           | 51,869  | 25,677 | 19,255 | 5,026     | 1,01,827        |
| SC (1)            | 572     | 272    | 518    | 28        | 1,390           |
| Total (60)        | 72,473  | 35,810 | 43,000 | 7,394     | 1,58,677        |

The Hindu analysed the numbers using the booth-wise lists of deletions published by the Chief Electoral Officer (CEO), Manipur. The Statewide aggregate numbers provided by the CEO did not include the breakdown of deletions marked as “Shifted” and as “Absent”. They were clubbed under a single category

**Table 3:** For every 1,000 male voters deleted, 1,271 female voters got deleted

\*(Number of female voters per 1,000 male voters)

| Gender        | In rolls before SIR | in deletions | in draft SIR rolls |
|---------------|---------------------|--------------|--------------------|
| Male          | 1,010,337           | 69,871       | 9,40,466           |
| Female        | 1,082,459           | 88,799       | 9,93,660           |
| Third Gender  | 300                 | 7            | 293                |
| Total         | 2,093,096           | 158,677      | 1,934,419          |
| Gender Ratio* | 1,071               | 1,271        | 1,057              |

## FROM THE ARCHIVES

The Hindu.

FIFTY YEARS AGO JULY 13, 1976

## Building Code that has been given the go-by

Madras, July 12: When there was a National Building Code why not make use of it to have cheaper buildings? Posing this question the Union Industry Minister, Mr. T. A. Pai, had a dig at financial institutions for putting forth their own codes “which were totally irrelevant” and which only added to costs.

Speaking at the Indian Standards Institution here today, Mr. Pai said that if one had to borrow from the LIC it would insist on earthquake proof foundation. If it was so keen why not have an earthquake premium instead of insisting on conditions which would only raise costs, he asked jocularly. The Minister also deprecated the tendency of industries to fritter away their resources on posh buildings.

Mr. Pai said that the National Building Code evolved a long time ago had been given the go-by and the PWD and the municipal corporations refused to change. People refused to do anything sensibly. It would appear that enforcement of discipline either by law or force was the only way to “discipline ourselves”, he felt.

The Minister was glad that the National Building Code was beginning to be accepted and the Planning Commission was making the State Governments to accept the code.

**A HUNDRED YEARS AGO JULY 13, 1926**

## The Lenglen episode

A correspondent of “The Star” wrote under date June 24. –

The biggest sensation of the present Wimbledon meeting occurred to-day, when Mlle. Suzanne Lenglen, the famous French tennis player, failed to put in an appearance for her two o’clock match on Court No. 1 against Mrs. G. J. Deyhurst. The meeting of these two had attracted the usual enormous crowd to Court No. 1 there being almost empty benches in the Centre Court, where J. Kozeluh and J. Pennycuik were appearing and at other attractive matches in other courts.

The court was packed, and thousands tried in vain to get in. But as time went on there was no Suzanne and the frequent applause testified to the impatience of the spectators. It was the first time in the history of Wimbledon that she was not up to time or that she has kept her faithful army of admirers waiting.







AAP demands strict action against temple theft culprits

**The Hindu Bureau**  
NEW DELHI

The Aam Aadmi Party launched a nationwide signature campaign on Sunday demanding strict punishment for those involved in *chanda chori* (theft of offerings) from the Ram Temple in Ayodhya.

Addressing people at a programme in Delhi, AAP national convener Arvind Kejriwal said he was signing a letter to Prime Minister Narendra Modi along with devotees present to demand justice.

“We will not rest until those who committed this dacoity at Lord Ram’s home are brought to justice and hanged,” he said.

He said the “dacoity” had deeply hurt Ram *bhakts* across the world. “Seventy incidents of theft over 40 days were captured on CCTV. Then eight months of CCTV recordings were deleted. All of us kept demanding action. We believed that those at the top would do something. But now it has become clear that they will do nothing because people from their own party, their own organisations, and all their affiliated organisations are involved,” he said.

# RSS expresses concern over Ram Temple embezzlement

The outfit expresses confidence in SIT probe; spokesperson says delegates at regional conveners’ meeting held in Belagavi underscored the need for measures to ensure such incidents don’t recur

**The Hindu Bureau**  
BELAGAVI

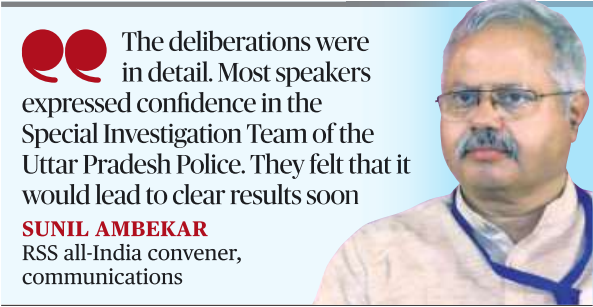
The Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) on Sunday expressed concern over the alleged embezzlement of donations at the Ram Temple in Ayodhya in Uttar Pradesh.

Delegates at the annual Akhil Bharatiya Prant Pracharak Baithak, held in Belagavi, underscored the need for measures to ensure that such incidents do not recur, a spokesperson said on the concluding day of the three-day meeting.

Sunil Ambekar, the RSS’s all-India convener, communications, said the Ram Temple embezzlement case was discussed during the regional conveners’ meeting.

### Detailed deliberations

“The deliberations were in detail. Most speakers expressed confidence in the Special Investigation Team (SIT) of the Uttar Pradesh Police. They felt that it would lead to clear results soon. The investigation was taken up after a request by the Shri Ram Jan-



mabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust. It was also decided to conduct the activities of the temple in such a way as not to disturb the faith of devotees,” he said.

Mr. Ambekar said that the meeting, held in the Sant Meera school in Angol, was attended by regional conveners from all States, office-bearers and executives, and heads of all 42 organisations affiliated to the RSS.

“RSS Sara Sanghachalak Mohan Bhagwat and Sara Karyavaha Dattatreya Hosabale, and other senior leaders attended and addressed some sessions. As many as 226 Pracharaks from across the country, 83 Sangh Shiksha Varga members and 12 Karyakarta Vikas Varga members partici-

pated. As many as 18,842 volunteers were trained in the three-day event,” he said.

### The issues discussed

The delegates discussed the “current situation” in the country, including organisational expansion, social initiatives, and national issues. “Speakers expressed concern about the demographic changes and population imbalance and the pan-India Census. Discussions focused on the working of the RSS, and national issues like rural development, family welfare, disaster management, environmental protection and other issues,” Mr. Ambekar said.

He said the leadership held a review on the prepa-

rations for the RSS centenary celebrations. “The leadership also reviewed the implementation of action plans at the *shakha* level and discussed an intensive expansion drive planned for September to increase the number of *shakhas* across the country. A review of the RSS centenary celebrations was held. Discussions for the preparations for the valedictory planned for October were held.”

“There was a proposal for engaging people who participated in centenary programmes in long-term social service activities and the ‘five-fold transformation’ initiative of the RSS was discussed. The annual travel programme of Dr. Bhagwat for 2026-27 was finalised,” he said.

Some senior leaders addressed the issue of drug abuse. “They emphasised the need for a strong de-addiction movement in the country.” Mr. Ambekar added, “Some others spoke of the RSS’s role in the programme to commemorate the 650th birth anniversary of Sant Shiromani Ravidas Maharaj.”

# ‘Temple Trust to decide powers of CEO, there will not be govt. interference’

**Press Trust of India**  
AYODHYA

Ram Temple Construction Committee Chairman Nripendra Misra on Sunday stated that the responsibilities and powers of the first-ever Chief Executive Officer (CEO) of the Ayodhya temple would be determined by the temple Trust.

The primary responsibility of the CEO would be to uphold the faith of devotees in the Trust, he said.

“The new CEO will also oversee financial arrangements,” Mr. Misra told reporters in Ayodhya, adding that there would not be any “government interference” in the functioning of the Trust or its CEO.

Mr. Misra added that ensuring that devotees visiting Ayodhya receive all necessary amenities and maintaining their trust in the temple would be among the new CEO’s initial responsibilities.

“In a way, the CEO will work as an assistant of the Trust, sans government interference,” Mr. Misra said, noting that a three-member panel has been set up to recommend candidates for the Trust’s CEO post.

Ultimately, it was up to



Nripendra Misra

the Trust to determine how much authority to delegate to the CEO, who would be responsible for arranging their own staff, while everything remained under the Trust’s purview, Mr. Misra stated.

On July 6, the Trust announced a three-member committee comprising Justice Pramod Kohli (retired), Lieutenant-General Vishnukant Chaturvedi (retired), and former NIT-Raipur Chairperson Suresh Haware to screen candidates for the CEO post.

Mr. Misra flatly denied when asked if he would attend the meetings of the committee tasked with recommending names for the CEO post.

He said there had been no complaints from devotees visiting the Ram Tem-

ple, and that they felt positively about their experience.

“If you ask the devotees near Angad Teela and Sugriv Kila about their feelings, I assure you there is no complaint regarding their faith in Lord Ram, the temple arrangements, or the worship taking place here,” he said.

Regarding any potential changes in the Trust, he said, “No decisions were made in my presence.” He also clarified that he did not attend the meeting of the Trust on July 6.

Asked if he would attend the meeting scheduled for July 22, Mr. Misra said, “The meeting is on July 22, but I do not know the agenda. If the matter pertains to construction, I would have to be present. Please understand, we are ex-officio directors without voting rights. We provide our views on relevant subjects. After I know the agenda, I will decide whether to attend.”

Regarding what might be discussed in the July 22 meeting, Mr. Misra suggested that this question should be directed to the general secretary of the temple Trust.

# Cong. seeks to turn the tables on BJP using fund row

### NEWS ANALYSIS

**Sandeep Phukan**  
NEW DELHI

The Ayodhya dispute predates the rise of the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), but the Ram Janmabhoomi movement made it a key issue by which the party challenged the Congress’s template of secularism, which sought to keep religion and electoral politics separate.

The latest controversy of alleged misappropriation of donations at the Ram Temple has, however, given the Congress an opportunity to frame its attack against the Sangh Parivar’s control over the management of the temple.

“The BJP-RSS have captured the temple administration in an unauthorised manner,” former Rajasthan Chief Minister Ashok Gehlot said on July 7.

The Congress has mounted an unusually sustained campaign demanding action against the of-



The latest campaign reflects yet another nuanced repositioning of stance by the Congress on issues of the Ram Temple. FILE PHOTO

fice-bearers of the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust who have Vishwa Hindu Parishad (VHP)-Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) backgrounds. It has also asked Prime Minister Narendra Modi to break his “silence” on the issue and order a Supreme Court-monitored investigation.

The Congress has held eight press conferences in New Delhi and nearly 50 across the country over the past four days.

Though neither Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge nor Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sab-

ha Rahul Gandhi has spoken on the issue, the party plans to raise the matter during the Monsoon Session of Parliament, which begins on July 20.

The latest campaign reflects yet another nuanced repositioning of stance by the Congress on Ayodhya, an issue on which the party’s approach has evolved with time over the past four decades.

The Congress government led by Rajiv Gandhi was accused of facilitating the early stages of the Ram Janmabhoomi movement when, in 1986, the locks of the disputed structure

were ordered to be opened, allowing Hindu devotees access to the site.

The move was seen as an attempt to assuage Hindu sentiment in the wake of the political fallout over the Shah Bano alimony case, in which the Supreme Court (SC) ruled that Muslim women were entitled to maintenance. When a section of Muslim clergy protested against the order as interference in Muslim Personal Law, the Rajiv Gandhi government enacted the Muslim Women (Protection of Rights on Divorce) Act, 1986, to dilute the top court’s order.

Three years later, in November 1989, the Narayan Dutt Tiwari-led Congress government in Uttar Pradesh permitted *shilanyas* (foundation-laying ceremony) adjacent to the disputed structure. The government maintained that the proposed site for the *shilanyas* lay outside the disputed area and that permitting the ceremony would therefore not violate the *status quo* ordered by

the courts. After the demolition of the Babri Masjid on December 6, 1992, the Congress sharply distanced itself from the movement. Prime Minister P.V. Narasimha Rao condemned the demolition, dismissed BJP governments in four States, and pledged to rebuild the mosque if the courts so directed.

Over the following decades, the party consistently defended the constitutional principle that the dispute should be resolved through the judiciary while arguing that the Places of Worship (Special Provisions) Act, 1991, should remain the main framework for all other religious sites.

The SC’s unanimous verdict in November 2019 allowing the construction of Ram Temple marked another turning point. Welcoming the verdict, the Congress Working Committee (CWC) said that all parties to the dispute should honour the judicial process and the rule of law.

“We appeal to all the parties concerned and to

all communities to abide by the secular values and the spirit of fraternity enshrined in our Constitution and to maintain peace and harmony,” the CWC resolution of November 9, 2019, said.

“The Indian National Congress favours the construction of the Ram temple,” senior leader Randeep Surjewala, who was then the party’s communications chief, told reporters after reading out the CWC statement.

But the Congress’s top leadership avoided attending the *pran pratishtha* (consecration) ceremony on January 22, 2024, describing it as a VHP-RSS event from which the Shankaracharyas were kept away.

Now, as the spotlight falls on the Trust’s office-bearers, the party, by seeking accountability and transparency and asserting that the temple belongs to devotees rather than the Sangh Parivar, is attempting to recast the narrative on Ayodhya and reclaim some political ground.

# Amid talks of switch to BJP, NCP (SP) leader says he is with Pawar

**Press Trust of India**  
MUMBAI

NCP (SP) leader Eknath Khadse on Sunday acknowledged that he travelled to Delhi, but asserted he was no longer interested in rejoining the BJP and would remain with Sharad Pawar till the end.

Mr. Khadse, a former BJP leader, is currently a Member of the State Legislative Council (MLC) from the Sharad Pawar-led Nationalist Congress Party (SP). Recently, it was reported that BJP general secretary Vinod Tawde had called on Mr. Khadse at his residence, fuelling speculation about the leader’s return to the saffron party.

Mr. Khadse said it was only a courtesy call. “He

enquired about my health and there was no political discussion. I invited him to my birthday function. I have also invited Nitin Gadkari, and he has told me he will attend,” the MLC said.

“I want to make it clear that I have no interest in joining the BJP now. I am with Sharad Pawar and will remain with him till the end. My workers may be interested in joining the BJP, but I am not,” he asserted.

During the 2024 Lok Sabha election campaign, reports of Mr. Khadse’s possible return to the BJP had gained traction after photographs of his meetings with senior party leaders in New Delhi surfaced. However, the move did not materialise.

# Bengal BJP chief calls Forward Bloc members goons; party seeks apology

**Shiv Sahay Singh**  
KOLKATA

While lauding the contributions of Bharatiya Jana Sangh founder Syama Prasad Mookerjee, West Bengal BJP president Samik Bhattacharya recently hit out at the All India Forward Bloc (AIFB), a party founded by Netaji Subhas Chandra Bose, calling its members “goons”.

Mr. Bhattacharya, a Rajya Sabha member, said that when Mookerjee urged Bose and his brother Sarat Chandra to raise their voice against torture of Hindus in Bangladesh, they did not listen. These remarks drew sharp criticism from the followers of Netaji and AIFB leaders.

AIFB general secretary G. Devarajan on July 11



Samik Bhattacharya, on July 6, said Syama Prasad Mookerjee was attacked by AIFB supporters during speech at Md. Ali Park. ANI

wrote to BJP national president Nitin Nabin demanding that he immediately direct Mr. Bhattacharya “to withdraw his derogatory statement unconditionally and issue a public apology to the Forward Bloc and to the people of the country.” “We further urge you to

instruct all BJP leaders in West Bengal to desist from making irresponsible statements against Netaji, to refrain from any attempt to erase or diminish his legacy through symbolic or administrative actions, and to respect the established history of India’s freedom

movement,” he said.

At a public gathering on July 6, Mr. Bhattacharya said that Mookerjee was attacked by AIFB supporters while giving a speech at Md. Ali Park.

The very next day, Mr. Bhattacharya said, “When Hindus were being tortured in Bangladesh between 1937 and 1939, Syama Prasad approached Subhas Chandra Bose and Sarat Bose, requesting them to raise their voice and issue statements. Neither listened to Mookerjee.”

“It is equally well documented that Netaji repeatedly cautioned Mookerjee against delivering speeches that could inflame communal passions and disturb public peace,” Mr. Devarajan had written in the letter.

# Narottam accepts BJP’s bypoll choice after visiting Delhi

**Mehul Malpani**  
BHOPAL

Days after the BJP picked another candidate over him for the bypoll in Madhya Pradesh’s Datia, the State’s former Home Minister Narottam Mishra, who went to Delhi on Sunday, denied meeting any leader from the party’s high command, saying he “wasn’t called” to the national capital and “went (there) just like that”.

Sources said Mr. Mishra met Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) national president Nitin Nabin. He was “instructed to back down and calm his supporters in Datia and work for the party’s candidate”, a source said.

The visit took place on a day party leaders held meetings in Datia to review preparedness for the July 30 Assembly byelection.

Late on Saturday, Mr. Mishra met Chief Minister Mohan Yadav, State BJP chief Hemant Khandelwal and the party’s zonal general secretary (organisation) Ajay Jamwal in Bhopal. The meetings came amid murmurs of him resenting the party denying him the ticket and fielding debutant Ashutosh Tiwari instead. The move had triggered massive protests in Datia where Mr. Mishra’s supporters turned violent. The police registered FIRs



Narottam Mishra

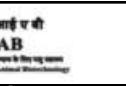
against more than 20 BJP workers after at least eight police personnel, including the SP and Additional SP, were injured.

Speaking in New Delhi, Mr. Mishra termed the protests a result of “sudden anger”. “Today, all the main people [BJP leaders] are in Datia and they [the workers] have put forth their views. Everything has calmed down now.”

Once considered among the influential BJP leaders in the State, Mr. Mishra said it has now been established that he does not have a “tall stature”.

On rumours that he was denied the ticket on the insistence of some senior State BJP leaders, Mr. Mishra said, “No, I don’t blame the organisation, nor do I blame the Chief Minister. I do not point fingers at anyone. I believe that there must have been some shortcoming on my part. I will introspect and improve myself.”

### APPOINTMENT



**ब्रिक-राष्ट्रीय पशु जैव प्रौद्योगिकी संस्थान**  
**BRIC-National Institute of Animal Biotechnology**  
(An Autonomous Institute of Dept. of Biotechnology, Ministry of Science & Technology, Govt. of India)  
Near Gowildoddi, Gachibowli, Hyderabad, Telangana India - 500 032.  
Tel: +91 40 2312 0103/115, Email: [admin@niab.org.in](mailto:admin@niab.org.in); Web: [www.niab.res.in](http://www.niab.res.in)  
(**Advt. No. 16/2026**)

BRIC-NIAB, an autonomous institute under the aegis of the Department of Biotechnology, Ministry of Science & Technology, Government of India, is aimed to harness novel and emerging biotechnologies and create knowledge in the cutting edge areas for improving animal health and productivity. The Institute invites applications from Indian citizens for the following positions:

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For more details, please visit NIAB website [www.niab.res.in](http://www.niab.res.in)  
Date of commencement of online applications: 13<sup>th</sup> July 2026  
Last date for submitting online applications: 14<sup>th</sup> August 2026 by 5 PM

**Sd/- DIRECTOR, NIAB**



INBRIEF



Pune building collapse: last body found, toll rises to nine

Rescue teams recovered the body of the last missing person in the Moshi waste processing unit collapse near Pune in the early hours of Sunday, taking the death toll in the tragedy to nine, officials said. Meanwhile, a senior official at the waste-processing plant described the July 8 incident as an “act of God”. The three-storey administrative building of a Waste-to-Energy (WTE) plant run by the Pimpri Chinchwad Municipal Corporation at Moshi in Pune district collapsed after the adjacent mound of garbage fell onto the structure like a landslide. The body of Waman Kasbe, the last missing person, was recovered from the rubble, while 14 persons have been rescued earlier, officials said. PTI

India, Canada conclude third round of talks on trade pact

India and Canada concluded the third round of negotiations for the proposed Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement in Ottawa on Friday as the two sides look to wind up the talks this year. The issues that figured in the five-day talks include trade in goods, services, intellectual property, rules of origin, sanitary measures, and technical barriers to trade, among others. The negotiations are important as the two sides seek to increase bilateral trade to \$50 billion by 2030. In 2025-26, the two-way trade dipped 8.22% to \$7.95 billion (\$4.67 billion exports, \$3.28 billion imports) from \$8.66 billion in 2024-25 (\$4.22 billion exports, \$4.44 billion imports). PTI

Flash floods wreak havoc in Pahalgam; buildings affected

Peerzada Ashiq  
SRINAGAR

As flash floods due to cloudbursts in the past 24 hours caused damage to several hotels in Pahalgam, a hill station in south Kashmir, the Opposition Peoples Democratic Party (PDP) and activists on Sunday flagged the “rampant construction in violation of environmental norms”.

On Saturday, four hotels and multiple houses were damaged when gushing waters in the Awoora stream swept away vehicles and entered hotel premises. Officials said scores of tourists were shifted to safer locations. A major road connecting Bijbehara and Pahalgam was cut off. “I interacted with affected families, and directed the departments concerned to ensure immediate rescue, relief, and restoration measures. Ev-



Shock disaster: A damaged house after a cloudburst triggered flash floods in Pahalgam in Jammu and Kashmir on Sunday. PTI

ery possible assistance would be provided to help them recover from this difficult situation,” Pahalgam legislator Altaf Ahmad Kaloo said. PDP leader Iltija Mufti said a mafia was operating in ecologically fragile Pahalgam, “allowing wanton illegal construction”. “Hotels are encroaching upon flood channels or forest land. It is ill-thought and detrimental to Kashmir’s environment already reel-

ing from global warming. I haven’t seen Pahalgam in such a mess before,” Ms. Mufti said. Sahil Parray, an activist, said the administration was hiding the data related to hotel construction in Pahalgam. Mr. Parray said Pahalgam faced unchecked commercialisation, rampant construction, shrinking green cover and apparent disregard for environmental safeguards.

ISRO successfully carries out tests of Gaganyaan systems

One of the tests involved separation of the ‘umbilical mechanism’ that serves as a link between the crew module, where astronauts live, and the service module that provides propulsion, agency says

Press Trust of India  
NEW DELHI

The Indian Space Research Organisation on Sunday said it had successfully carried out three major tests of the Gaganyaan crew module systems.

The first test pertained to ensuring an upright position of the crew module after splashdown in the sea, considered one of the most important crew safety requirements. To do this, a stored cold-gas-based uprighting system was developed and tested.

“A system-level qualification test set-up consisting of all the elements of CMUS (crew module uprighting system) was realised,” the ISRO said, adding it successfully conducted inflation tests “for the primary inflation module wherein stored gas in the high-pressure gas bottle was made to inflate the floatation by operating the control valves.”

The second test involved examining the separation of the umbilical mechanism that serves as a link between the crew module, where astronauts live, and the service module, which provides pow-



Step-by-step: (Clockwise from left) The crew module uprighting system, the service module connect-disconnect system, and the apex cover that underwent testing. ISRO



er and propulsion. The mechanism consists of two parts, each located at the crew module side, called CSU-1, and the service module side, called CSU-2.

Clean separation

During the crew module’s earth re-entry stage, the service module first separates from the crew mo-

dule after the CSU-1 disconnects. Subsequently, just before re-entry, the CSU-2 is also separated.

“Separation test of CSU-2 from simulated crew module was carried out. The test demonstrated the clean separation of CSU-2 as well as structural stability of the crew module panel and their interfaces,”

the space agency said. The third test validated the structural integrity of the crew module during the apex cover separation event. The apex cover protects the parachutes and associated subsystems during the mission. It is separated before parachutes are deployed to decelerate the crew module.

CJI stresses need for women-centric infrastructure in judicial buildings

The Hindu Bureau  
GURUGRAM

Chief Justice of India Surya Kant on Sunday said judicial infrastructure was no longer a luxury but a “very big necessity”, and called for mandatory facilities for women advocates, including separate Bar rooms and adjoining childcare facilities, in all new court complexes.

Speaking at the inauguration of the new Tower of Justice, a seven-acre judicial complex for the Gurugram District and Sessions Court near Rajiv Chowk, the Chief Justice said providing an atmosphere that instils confidence in socially and financially backward litigants was the duty of all three organs of the Constitution.

“Just as a patient reaching a hospital is given first-aid, a consumer of justice



Chief Justice of India Surya Kant speaking at the inauguration of a judicial complex in Gurugram on Sunday. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

coming to court must be given first-aid in the form of basic amenities – seating, drinking water, and wash-rooms,” Chief Justice Kant said. He noted that Gurugram’s transformation from an agricultural town to an industrial hub had led to a sharp rise in legal disputes of all kinds.

Flagging the lack of facilities for women lawyers,

the CJI cited a recent Supreme Court Bar Association survey, which found that many judicial complexes across States lacked basic amenities for women members of the Bar. “Women advocates are not being provided the facilities that should be given to them in many States. It is our all-out effort that wherever new judicial infras-

ESIC to add 7 more healthcare facilities to its infra network

The Hindu Bureau  
NEW DELHI

The Employees’ State Insurance Corporation (ESIC) will add seven more healthcare facilities to its infrastructure network in six States. Union Minister for Labour Mansukh Mandaviya will inaugurate the projects at Sanathnagar in Telangana on Tuesday.

Apart from the new Out-patient Department Block of ESIC Hospital in Sanathnagar, upgraded 200-bed ESIC Hospital, Beltola, Assam; 100-bed ESIC hospital in Sripurumbudur, Tamil Nadu; hospital in Rajamahendravaram, Andhra Pradesh; dispensary and branch offices in Surendranagar, Gujarat, and Kota, Rajasthan; and ESI Dispensary at Bhawani Mandi, Rajasthan are the new facilities.

“These medical facilities, worth approximately ₹668 crore, will cater to the healthcare needs of around 53 lakh beneficiaries across the country,” the Union Labour Ministry said in a release on Sunday.

The new facility in Sanathnagar, the government said, is a landmark healthcare facility that will provide modern, comprehensive outpatient services to over 12.3 lakh insured

‘These facilities will cater to healthcare needs of around 53 lakh beneficiaries across the country’

persons and beneficiaries across Telangana.

The ESIC Hospital in Beltola, Assam, caters to 47 districts of Assam and Meghalaya, as well as 41 districts across Tripura, Mizoram, Manipur, Nagaland and Arunachal Pradesh. “The facility is expected to cover 3.42 lakh insured persons, and a total of about 13.27 lakh beneficiaries,” the government said.

The ESIC Hospital located at Sripurumbudur will cater to 5.5 lakh insured persons from Kancheepuram and Tiruvallur districts. The hospital at Rajamahendravaram, Andhra Pradesh will serve over 1.3 lakh insured persons, while 9,192 insured persons are covered under the ESIC scheme in Surendranagar district.

The Kota facility will cater to 1,500 employers, and about 75,000 insured persons. The Bhawani Mandi facility will provide healthcare services to about 800 employers and 27,715 insured persons.

Centre brings new scheme to regularise PF Trusts

The Hindu Bureau  
NEW DELHI

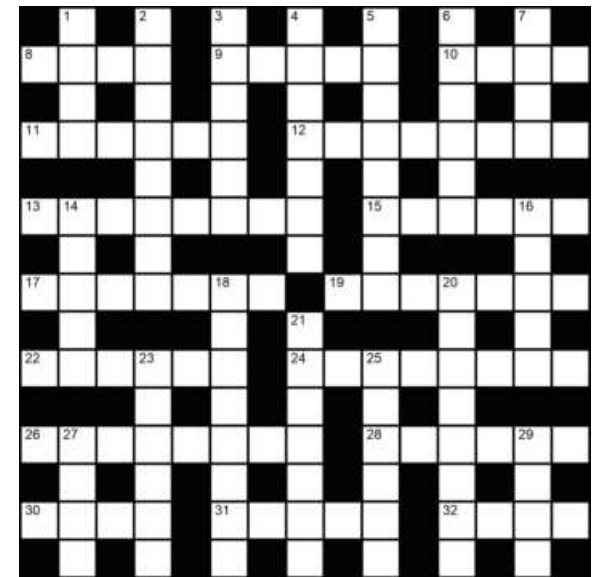
The EPFO has invited applications from exempted Provident Fund Trusts to regularise their status under provisions of the Finance Act, 2026, the Income Tax Act, 2026, and the Code on Social Security. The Amnesty Scheme, 2026, provides a one-time opportunity for the Trusts recognised under the Income Tax Act, 1961 to regularise their status.

Recognition under the Income Tax Act, 2025 shall be available only to Provident Funds that have obtained exemption under Section 17 of the Employees’ Provident Fund and Misc. Provisions Act, 1952. The scheme applies to establishments that do not possess formal exemption from the government.

THE CROSSWORD+ 14844

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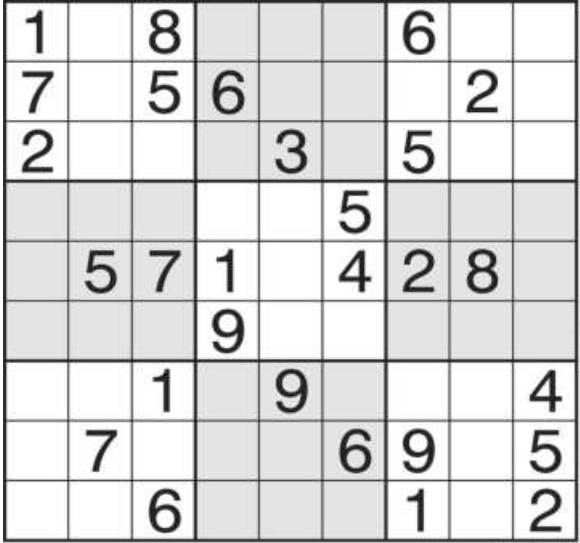
SCAN TO PLAY



- Across
- 8 Repeat, "E for \_\_\_\_" (4)  
9 Lather bubbling forth (5)  
10 Pours tea on top of saucer and consumes (4)  
11 Place to keep horses from second list (6)  
12 Owed mint production for unproductive period (8)  
13 Simmers esculents to some extent and dips (8)

- 15 Uncannily Easter lily breaks into pieces in absence of salt (6)  
17 Gives air conditioning cables (7)  
19 Set down reason: "Rib case is broken" (7)  
22 Peril from violent gander (6)  
24 Tell, "Rosy damaged vehicles" (8)  
26 Forged notes with Scotsman and European (8)  
28 Sit back, with a north European beverage (6)  
30 Challenge from Kakinada region (4)  
31 Trendy to be in vessel and sea-craft (5)  
32 Cupid shreds rose (4)
- Down
- 1 Caledonian manages cost! (4)  
2 After a second, silly Romeo accepts British hat (8)  
3 In absence of in-charge, officers produce tenders (6)  
4 Female deity and Greek leader on strange English ship (7)  
5 Thick soups that cowherds produce (8)  
6 Landlord's communication (6)  
7 Something to split found in Muscat, Oman (4)  
14 Excitedly came across head of caliphate in holy city (5)  
16 Campaign in the foyer (5)  
18 Most unclean red tits fly around island (8)  
20 At end of dinner, she lied cunningly, "Enjoyed" (8)  
21 Silent characters going around college, producing means of reproduction (7)  
23 What a crazy lover might do when after girl? (6)  
25 Dull-witted subordinate moving around after dropping dinar (6)  
27 Cover for wound from barricades raider leaves in disarray (4)  
29 Gas none may produce (4)

SUDOKU



Solution to previous puzzle

Solution to yesterday's Sudoku

FAITH

God is within you

A few people may be caught in earthly pursuits (of material wealth) but when one fails to identify the presence of Perumal within, it is indeed the end of everything. This is what happened to Hiranyakasipu. Angered at the death of his brother Hiranyaksha at the hands of Varaha (Vishnu's avatar) for abducting Bhu Devi, Hiranyakasipu vowed to wage war on Vishnu. To this end, he first harassed cows and bhagavatas (devotees) as he knew they were dear to Vishnu. However, the Supreme Being did not take the bait, which frustrated Hiranyakasipu and he stormed into Vaikunta, but Perumal left from there forthwith, said Damal S. Ramakrishnan.

The moment Hiranyakasipu entered Vaikunta, Perumal entered his heart, but the demon did not realise the god within. Instead, he left Vaikunta and undertook severe penance and sought a boon from Brahma which he thought was armour enough against Perumal. On the other hand, Hiranyakasipu's unborn son Prahlada was a symbol of devotion even when he was in the womb of his mother Kayadhu. She was under the protection of Narada and the sage discoursed on puranas and the many characteristics of Perumal. This grounding in spiritual knowledge helped Prahlada remain steadfast in the face of severe test of his devotion, from none other than his own father. Vishnu manifested as Nrisimha, a half-man, half-lion form, and sank his nails into Hiranyakasipu's heart. Scholars say Nrisimha plucked and searched the demon's heart for the presence of any godliness or devotion in him: even a modicum of awareness of the Supreme Being within would have saved the demon.



# Claims quantified, mom’s love priceless

## COVERNOTE

K. Nitya Kalyani

Parents are invaluable, but insurance needs a rupee value basis for compensating financial loss. Thus long, a woman with no independent earnings and essentially a housewife, did not warrant a compensation in motor accident third-party liability cases. Now a value has been fixed for her life, enabling compensation. The Supreme Court fixed ₹30,000 a month as the minimum economic value of her contribution in terms of unpaid domestic work and caregiving, to serve as the basis for compensation.

This ruling was part of a landmark judgment delivered on June 11, 2026 in an appeal in a motor accident claim for a 2001 accident in Punjab in which a housewife died. It highlighted that unpaid domestic and caregiving work, mostly the lot of women, forms about 15% of the country’s Gross Domestic Product (GDP) but has never been quantified or formalised as a metric. The fact is that a homemaker’s work, though unpaid, carries enormous financial and societal value.

As a result of this ruling, a new legal category called “Loss of Domestic Care” has been created in the compensation table in the Motor Vehicles Act (MVA), 1988 and under this, the insurance company cannot follow the earlier method of ascribing a nil value for compensation as in the case of unskilled labourers.

### Some background

Motor Third-Party Liability (TP) insurance compensates the insured for any legal liability to a third party created by his vehicle in an accident, including death.

MVA 1988 introduced a mathematical formula and a matrix for automatically calculating compensation amounts for death which could be awarded by courts where the income of the deceased was ₹40,000 a month or less.

Called structured compensation, it took into account the deceased’s earnings, earnings potential in the future, his or her age and adjusted it for personal expenses.

By this it provided a solution that all the parties, the courts, the insurance companies and the victims’ families could make peace with and not litigate endlessly in hopes of unknown high compensations. The matrix did not have a category relating to homemakers and so their life value was taken as nil, as in the case of unskilled labourers, while deciding compensation in cases.

Clearly, the multiple roles a wife or mother plays to keep the home running and the family cared for has a much higher market price than zero, should they be outsourced to professionals.

### Impact on insurance and claims

In the case on which the Supreme Court Bench was ruling, the compensation earlier fixed at ₹8.43 lakh by the High Court was raised to ₹62.78 lakh.

The Supreme Court clarified that this ruling does not legally enforce a monthly salary to be paid to housewives by their husbands. Though one wishes!

Also of significance is that the ₹30,000 per month is a minimum and Motor Accident Claims Tribunals (MACT), special courts for Motor TP accident claims, can use this as a starting point for fixing compensation and individual cases can be built for higher compensations.

There is also a built in 10% increase on this baseline amount every three years for inflation.

The impact on various types of claims/cases will unfold as time goes on. On the underwriting front, homemakers could not get life insurance till now as they had no formal income and this would change enabling policies to be taken on their lives. One is sure new policies are being designed for the whole new segment that has been opened up.

One is even more sure that the premium rates for motor TP policies will go up to take care of additional claims they have to pay out under this category!

(The writer is a business journalist specialising in insurance & corporate history)



Millions of households still either do not have adequate term cover or postpone purchasing it altogether. ILLUSTRATION: B. SAINATH ILLUSTRATION: B. SAINATH

# Bridging the affordability gap in term life insurance

With lower servicing and acquisition costs caused by digital underwriting, pricing is becoming better and more efficient, resulting in meaningful improvement in affordability

## COST EFFECTIVE

Vivek Jain

India is home to several households where a single income often supports an entire family or even generations. Life insurance is one of the most important financial tools for protecting household income, with term insurance remaining its simplest and most affordable form. Yet, despite widespread awareness about its importance, India continues to remain significantly under-protected. Millions of households still either do not have adequate term cover or postpone purchasing it altogether.

And it is not always about the lack of intent. More often than not, it is a combination of affordability concerns, complicated underwriting, documentation fatigue, and the perception that term life insurance is difficult to buy.

Technology, digital distribution, and data-led underwriting are reshaping how insurance is bought, assessed, and priced in India. These shifts are beginning to reshape the broader life insurance ecosystem, although their impact is perhaps most visible in term insurance, where underwriting has the greatest influence on pricing.

More importantly, these innovations are helping the industry address one of its biggest structural challenges, which is affordability.



Insurers today increasingly use AI-led underwriting models which can make accurate predictions about future risks based on digital records

Instead of calculating the premium based solely on manual evaluations and broad risk categories, insurers today increasingly use AI-led underwriting models which can make accurate predictions about future risk based on the customers’ digital medical records, prescription history analysis, and behavioural data signals.

What this means is that instead of having a generalised pricing for every consumer, insurance companies are now moving towards more individualised risk assessment.

India’s Digital Public Infrastructure has strengthened this shift. Consent-based e-KYC, the Account Aggregator framework and the gradual expansion of digital health records are giving insurers access to richer, verified data with customer consent, reducing both friction and underwriting uncertainty.

As a result, healthy customers with stable financial behaviour and low-risk lifestyle indicators can often receive faster approvals and more competitive premiums than they would have under older underwriting systems. In many



Technology, digital distribution, and data-led underwriting are reshaping how insurance is bought, assessed, and priced in India

cases, insurers are now able to issue policies instantly or within hours instead of weeks. Better underwriting improves not just affordability, but portfolio quality, enabling insurers to grow sustainably without compromising on risk selection.

One of the most important developments driving this change has been accelerated underwriting. Rather than requiring every customer to undergo extensive medical testing, insurers now use intelligent triaging systems to identify low-risk applicants who may qualify for simplified or no-medical issuance. This significantly reduces friction for customers while also lowering operational costs for insurers.

As India’s health data ecosystem matures, interoperable digital health records could further reduce the need for repetitive medical tests and documentation, making underwriting faster while improving risk assessment quality.

With lower servicing and acquisition costs caused by digital underwriting, pricing is becoming better and more efficient,

resulting in meaningful improvement in affordability.

Historically, life insurers often priced products conservatively because they had limited visibility into individual risk profiles.

A lack of granular data meant that large customer pools were grouped together, with lower-risk individuals effectively subsidising higher-risk segments.

Digital underwriting is changing this equation. AI-led risk engines today assess hundreds of data points, from medical declarations and prescription histories to occupation profiles and financial behaviour, to arrive at a more nuanced assessment of mortality risk. This enables insurers to move away from one-size-fits-all pricing towards far sharper risk segmentation.

The impact is already visible. Women, for instance, typically enjoy significantly lower term insurance premiums than men because of their relatively higher life expectancy. Improved underwriting and richer actuarial data have enabled insurers to price this difference more accurately, with women often paying 15-30% lower premiums for similar covers. Similarly, non-smokers and individuals with favourable health profiles are increasingly benefiting from preferential pricing that would have been difficult under traditional underwriting models.

(The writer is Chief Business Officer, Life Insurance, Policybazaar)

## Bank Fixed Deposit Rates

| Bank Name                   | Interest Rates (%) |               |               |               |
|-----------------------------|--------------------|---------------|---------------|---------------|
|                             | Highest Slab       | 1-year Tenure | 3-year Tenure | 5-year Tenure |
| Small Finance Banks         |                    |               |               |               |
| AU Small Finance Bank       | 7.40               | 6.35          | 7.40          | 6.75          |
| Equitas Small Finance Bank  | 8.00               | 7.10          | 7.10          | 7.00          |
| ESAF Small Finance Bank     | 7.75               | 6.00          | 6.00          | 5.75          |
| Jana Small Finance Bank     | 8.00               | 7.00          | 8.00          | 7.77          |
| Shivalik Small Finance Bank | 8.00               | 6.00          | 7.50          | 6.25          |
| slice Small Finance Bank    | 7.75               | 6.25          | 7.50          | 7.00          |
| Suryoday Small Finance Bank | 8.10               | 7.25          | 7.25          | 7.90          |
| Ujjivan Small Finance Bank  | 7.80               | 7.25          | 7.25          | 7.20          |
| Utkarsh Small Finance Bank  | 8.10               | 6.00          | 7.50          | 7.00          |
| Private Sector Banks        |                    |               |               |               |
| Axis Bank                   | 6.50               | 6.25          | 6.50          | 6.50          |
| Bandhan Bank                | 7.45               | 7.00          | 7.25          | 5.85          |
| City Union Bank             | 7.25               | 6.65          | 6.50          | 6.55          |
| CSB Bank                    | 7.35               | 5.00          | 5.75          | 5.75          |
| DBS Bank                    | 6.85               | 6.30          | 6.40          | 6.25          |
| DCB Bank                    | 7.50               | 6.90          | 7.00          | 7.50          |
| Federal Bank                | 6.80               | 6.25          | 6.75          | 6.40          |
| HDFC Bank                   | 6.50               | 6.25          | 6.45          | 6.40          |
| ICICI Bank                  | 6.50               | 6.25          | 6.45          | 6.50          |
| IDFC FIRST Bank             | 7.35               | 6.50          | 7.35          | 6.75          |
| Indusind Bank               | 7.00               | 6.75          | 7.00          | 6.65          |

| Bank Name                | Interest Rates (%) |               |               |               |
|--------------------------|--------------------|---------------|---------------|---------------|
|                          | Highest Slab       | 1-year Tenure | 3-year Tenure | 5-year Tenure |
| Public Sector Banks      |                    |               |               |               |
| Jammu & Kashmir Bank     | 7.30               | 6.80          | 6.70          | 6.75          |
| IDBI Bank                | 6.50               | 6.20          | 6.35          | 6.25          |
| Karnataka Bank           | 7.00               | 6.50          | 6.15          | 6.15          |
| Kotak Mahindra Bank      | 6.80               | 6.35          | 6.40          | 6.25          |
| RBL Bank                 | 7.20               | 7.00          | 7.20          | 6.70          |
| SBM Bank India           | 7.30               | 7.10          | 7.10          | 7.00          |
| South Indian Bank        | 6.80               | 6.25          | 6.20          | 5.70          |
| Tamilnad Mercantile Bank | 7.25               | 6.80          | 6.70          | 6.70          |
| YES Bank                 | 7.25               | 6.65          | 7.00          | 6.75          |
| Public Sector Banks      |                    |               |               |               |
| Bank of Baroda           | 6.75               | 6.25          | 6.25          | 6.30          |
| Bank of India            | 6.85               | 6.50          | 6.70          | 6.00          |
| Bank of Maharashtra      | 6.65               | 6.40          | 5.25          | 5.00          |
| Canara Bank              | 6.60               | 6.25          | 6.25          | 6.25          |
| Central Bank of India    | 6.70               | 6.10          | 6.00          | 6.00          |
| Indian Bank              | 6.80               | 6.10          | 6.05          | 6.00          |
| Indian Overseas Bank     | 6.60               | 6.50          | 6.10          | 6.10          |
| Punjab National Bank     | 6.60               | 6.25          | 6.30          | 6.35          |
| Punjab & Sind Bank       | 6.85               | 5.85          | 5.85          | 5.95          |
| State Bank of India      | 6.45               | 6.25          | 6.30          | 6.05          |
| Union Bank of India      | 6.65               | 6.20          | 6.10          | 6.00          |

## Home Loan Interest Rates

| Name of Lender        | Loan Amount (Rs.) |                              |               |
|-----------------------|-------------------|------------------------------|---------------|
|                       | Upto 30 lakh      | Above 30 lakh & upto 75 lakh | Above 75 lakh |
| (In %)                |                   |                              |               |
| Public Sector Banks   |                   |                              |               |
| State Bank of India   | 7.25-9.05         | 7.25-9.05                    | 7.25-9.05     |
| Bank of Baroda        | 7.20-9.00         | 7.20-9.00                    | 7.20-9.05     |
| Union Bank of India*  | 7.15-9.60         | 7.15-9.60                    | 7.15-9.60     |
| Punjab National Bank  | 7.30-9.30         | 7.25-9.20                    | 7.25-9.20     |
| Bank of India         | 7.10-10.00        | 7.10-10.00                   | 7.10-10.25    |
| Bank of Maharashtra   | 7.10-9.90         | 7.10-9.90                    | 7.10-9.90     |
| Punjab and Sind Bank  | 7.30-10.70        | 7.30-10.70                   | 7.30-10.70    |
| Indian Overseas Bank  | 7.20 #            | 7.20 #                       | 7.20 #        |
| Indian Bank           | 7.15-9.55         | 7.15-9.55                    | 7.15-9.55     |
| Central Bank of India | 7.10-9.15         | 7.10-9.15                    | 7.10-9.15     |
| Private Sector Banks  |                   |                              |               |
| Kotak Mahindra Bank   | 7.60 #            | 7.60 #                       | 7.60 #        |
| ICICI Bank            | 7.55 #            | 7.55 #                       | 7.55 #        |
| Axis Bank             | 8.00-11.90        | 8.00-11.90                   | 8.00 - 9.10   |
| HSBC Bank             | 7.45 #            | 7.45 #                       | 7.45 #        |
| South Indian Bank     | 7.20 #            | 7.20 #                       | 7.20 #        |
| Karur Vysya Bank      | 8.50-10.65        | 8.50-10.65                   | 8.50-10.65    |
| Karnataka Bank        | 7.49-11.72        | 7.49-11.72                   | 7.49-11.72    |

| Name of Lender                                                                                           | Loan Amount (Rs.) |                              |               |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------|------------------------------|---------------|
|                                                                                                          | Upto 30 lakh      | Above 30 lakh & upto 75 lakh | Above 75 lakh |
| (In %)                                                                                                   |                   |                              |               |
| Housing Finance Companies (HFCs)                                                                         |                   |                              |               |
| Federal Bank                                                                                             | 8.35 - 10.25      | 7.35 - 10.25                 | 7.35 - 9.25   |
| Tamilnad Mercantile Bank                                                                                 | 7.90 - 9.30       | 7.90 - 9.30                  | 7.90 - 9.30   |
| Bandhan Bank                                                                                             | 8.55 - 13.52      | 8.55 - 13.52                 | 8.55 - 13.52  |
| RBL Bank                                                                                                 | 8.20 #            | 8.20 #                       | 8.20 #        |
| CSB Bank                                                                                                 | 8.30 #            | 8.30 #                       | 8.30 #        |
| HDFC Bank                                                                                                | 7.75 #            | 7.75 #                       | 7.75 #        |
| City Union Bank                                                                                          | 8.25-9.50         | 8.50-10.00                   | 8.75-10.50    |
| Housing Finance Companies (HFCs)                                                                         |                   |                              |               |
| LIC Housing Finance                                                                                      | 7.15 #            | 7.15 #                       | 7.15 #        |
| Bajaj Housing Finance                                                                                    | 7.25 #            | 7.25 #                       | 7.25 #        |
| Tata Capital                                                                                             | 8.00 #            | 8.00 #                       | 8.00 #        |
| PNB Housing Finance                                                                                      | 7.50 #            | 7.50 #                       | 7.50 #        |
| GIC Housing Finance                                                                                      | 8.20 #            | 8.20 #                       | 8.20 #        |
| SMFG India Home Finance                                                                                  | 9.25 #            | 9.25 #                       | 9.25 #        |
| Sammaan Capital                                                                                          | 8.75 #            | 8.75 #                       | 8.75 #        |
| Aditya Birla Capital                                                                                     | 7.75 #            | 7.75 #                       | 7.75 #        |
| ICICI Home Finance                                                                                       | 7.50 #            | 7.50 #                       | 7.50 #        |
| *Extra 0.05% concession to borrowers buying insurance Rates as on July 8 #onwards Source:Paisabazaar.com |                   |                              |               |

# The glide path for your equity allocation

## THINKINVESTOR

At 45, you should have an equity allocation of not more than 70% in your retirement portfolio; then on, you must reduce your equity allocation till you reach age 55 and maintain it till you retire

Venkatesh Bangaruswamy

Previously in this column, we discussed asset allocation funds. One of the main features of such funds is the glide path. In this article, we discuss the importance of glide path in the professional management of such funds.

### Slide rule

Picture a slide in a play area. Next, imagine a child climbing the steps and reaching the top of the slide only to gently slide down to reach the ground. Now, think of your equity allocation. When you start working, you gradually increase your equity allocation, just like the child climbing the stairs to reach the top of the slide.

You typically reach the top of the slide (maximum equity allocation) at age 45. That is when you should have an equity allocation of not more than 70% in your retirement portfolio. From then on, you must reduce your equity allocation (slide down) till you reach age 55 and then maintain the allocation till your retirement, presumably at 60. This process of reducing your equity allocation as you approach retirement is referred to as the glide path. Target date funds in the US adopted the glide path to reduce portfolio risk for investors approaching their retirement. Your retirement portfolio will have a large value as you approach retirement. Therefore, even a 15% price decline can be harmful for your portfolio. The glide path is a way to reduce this risk by cutting equity exposure and moving the sale proceeds to bonds.

### Conclusion

The NPS applies the glide path for the auto allocation option. More recently, SEBI has allowed asset management companies (AMCs) to offer lifecycle funds that also adopt a glide path. According to the SEBI regulation, lifecycle funds that have 15 years to target date can have between 65 and 95% in equity. This allocation should drop to between 50 and 65% when the target date is between 5 and 10 years, and to 20% or less when the target date is less than one year.

The range of glide path enables product differentiation among AMCs. A more aggressive fund will have higher equity allocation, dropping from 95% with 15 years to target date to 65% when the target date is 5 years away. A conservative fund may have a lower allocation, say, 65% 15 years to target date to 50% when the target date is 5 years away.

(The author offers training programmes for individuals to manage their personal investments)



## Nine-year-old girl among five killed in Israeli fire and air strikes in Gaza



## Chinese geologists question safety of Brahmaputra dam near India



## South Korea asks North Korea for help in finding missing Navy man



## Detained leader Suu Kyi will be looked after, Myanmar tells ASEAN



# Nine people killed as Russia, Ukraine intensify attacks against each other

# EU and 14 countries reaffirm ruling on South China Sea

# Hamad bin Khalifa, former leader and key architect of modern Qatar, dies aged 74

# Lindsey Graham, pivotal U.S. Republican Senator and a close Trump ally, dies at 71

# Sport

# Snehit does the star turn for Pune Jaguars

## Anand clinches the javelin gold; women's 4x400m team wins

CM  
Y  
K







INBRIEF



Carty and Hope steer Windies home against the Kiwis

Keacy Carty, *in pic.*, was dismissed on 95 and Shai Hope made an unbeaten 87 in a 131-run third wicket partnership which steered the West Indies to a seven-wicket win over New Zealand on Saturday in the first of the five One-Day Internationals in Guyana.

**The scores:** New Zealand 267 in 49.5 overs (Mitchell 65, Young 49, Alzarri 4/41, Lawes 3/54) lost to West Indies 268/3 in 48.5 overs (Carty 95, Hope 87 n.o.).  
**Toss:** West Indies. **PoM:** Carty.

Prince replaces injured Harshit in India ODI squad

Young pacer Harshit Rana and veteran spinner Varun Chakaravorthy have been ruled out of competitive cricket for indefinite period due to hamstring injuries of various degrees, while Prince Yadav and Ravi Bishnoi were named as their replacements for India's upcoming ODI and T20I assignments respectively. Prince will link up with the ODI squad in England in the absence of Harshit.



Argentina football legend Rattin passes away at 89

Former Argentina international Antonio Rattin, regarded as one of the country's finest midfielders and a Boca Juniors legend, passed away on Saturday at the age of 89. Rattin represented Argentina at the 1962 and 1966 FIFA World Cups. Rattin made 382 appearances for Boca Juniors between 1956 and 1970, scoring 28 goals and helping the club win four Argentine league titles.

Indian recurve archers lose bronze medal matches

Indian recurve archers missed out on podium finishes after losing the women's individual and mixed team bronze medal matches at the Archery World Cup Stage-4 in Madrid on Sunday.

**The results: Recurve: Women: Individual:** Kirti lost to Elif Gokkir (Tur) 3-7 (semifinals); lost to Oh Yejin (Kor) 1-7 (bronze medal match).  
**Mixed team:** India (Kirti, B. Dhiraj) lost to Italy (Roberta Di Francesco, Matteo Borsani) 3-5 (bronze match).

Marquez wins Germany MotoGP, equals record

Marc Marquez won the Germany MotoGP Grand Prix at Hohenstein-Ernstthal on Sunday, equalling Italian legend Giacomo Agostini's record of 10 premier class wins on a single circuit. The Spanish seven-time World champion started on pole as he glided to a dominant win, 1.996 seconds ahead of Japan's Ai Ogura in second with fellow Spaniard Raul Fernandez completing the podium.



Arshi sweeps Mini Max category at National karting

Ten-year-old Arshi Gupta won all four races in the Mini Max category in the second round of the 2026 MECO-FMSCI National Karting Championship (RMC India) at the Madras International Karting Arena (MIKA) in Chennai on Sunday. After qualifying second, Arshi won both heats, the pre-final, and the main final to complete a clean sweep and strengthen her title challenge. The performance came after a difficult opening round in Coimbatore and marked another milestone following her historic 2025 season, when she became the first female National champion in Rotax India history.

Rohit and Kohli will pose a 'double headache': Swann

The former England offie says the two veterans should be allowed to bow out on their own terms; feels captain Gill's batting prowess and Bumrah's return would serve India well in the ODI series

INDIA IN ENGLAND

S. Shrivathsan

Former England off-spinner Graeme Swann was suffering from the aftereffects of staying up all night for the FIFA World Cup quarterfinal matches.

Scheduled to address the media virtually on Sunday evening, Swann – currently on broadcast duty in India for the Men in Blue's tour of England – would not have minded more rest before facing the scribes. But when he was put on the spot, firstly with the most obvious question on Rohit Sharma and Virat Kohli's presence in the ODI series, he responded with clarity.

**Hails the chase-master** Swann opined that the 39-year-old Rohit and Kohli, 37, possess the tools to succeed despite not having age on their side.

“When Rohit and Virat play together, they pose a double headache for the fielding team. When India bats first, Rohit is the best I have seen... batting on a fresh pitch, taking the



**Plenty left in the tank:** Swann opines that Kohli and Rohit possess the tools to succeed despite not having age on their side. FILE PHOTO: K.R. DEEPAK

game away from the opposition and posting a big total,” said the 47-year-old.

“I believe that Virat is the greatest chaser we have ever witnessed; some of his knocks are stupendous. Having both is a massive bonus for India.”

He remarked that the veterans, who are one-format players nowadays, should be allowed to bow out of international cricket on their own terms.

“Because of the standards Rohit and Virat have set and careers they have had, it is up to them when they want to finish. I do not think that they have much to worry about because they are still brilliant players,” Swann added.

**Fresh impetus**

Swann felt that the batting might of ODI skipper Shubman Gill and return of ace pacer Jasprit Bumrah, be-

sides the quality of Rohit and Kohli, should provide India hope. “It is amazing to have players of that stature come straight back into the team. After the T20I series (where India was thrashed 0-4), you need fresh impetus.”

*(Watch the three-match ODI series between England and India live on Sony Sports Ten 1 SD & HD & Sony Sports Ten 5 SD & HD from July 14).*

Indrajith ton, Chandrasekar five-for headline Rovers' innings victory

FIRST DIVISION

Sports Bureau  
CHENNAI

Skipper B. Indrajith struck 118 (215b, 8x4) before left-arm spinner D.T. Chandrasekar claimed another five-for (5/69) to bowl out MRC-A for 125 to hand Jolly Rovers an innings-and-79-run victory on the second day of the TNCA first division league sixth-round match at IITM-Chemplast on Sunday.

Chandrasekar finished with match figures of 12 for 126 while left-arm spinner G. Shailender's five for 96 proved futile for MRC-A.

Opener S. Radhakrishnan converted his overnight century into a career-best 254 (405b, 32x4, 3x6) and shared a 172-run eighth-wicket stand with R. Sonu Yadav (98) as Nelson SC amassed 555 against Sea Hawks at the Tagore College ground. Left-arm spinner P. Saravanan claimed five for 173 for Sea Hawks.

Skipper S. Guru Raghavendran's unbeaten 100 (148b, 13x4) helped Globe Trotters declare on 453 for



Chandrasekar (Jolly Rovers, 5/69); Indrajith (Jolly Rovers, 118); Radhakrishnan (Nelson SC, 254).



Shailender (MRC-A, 5/96); Saravanan (Sea Hawks, 5/173).



Monish (Pristine, 7/84); Guru (Globe Trotters, 100 n.o.).

eight versus Swaraj. Left-arm spinner Monish Satish claimed seven for 84, but SKM secured a 144-run first-innings lead against Pristine.

**The scores (sixth round, day two):**  
**At Tagore:** Nelson SC 555 in 137.1 overs (S. Radhakrishnan 254, Sunny Sandhu 70, R. Sonu Yadav 98, P. Saravanan 5/173) vs. Sea Hawks 144 for no loss in 40 overs (B. Sachin 57 batting, N. Jagadeesan 85 batting).  
**At IITM-Chemplast:** MRC-A 130 & 125 in 30.2 overs (A.P. Ananda Kumar 53, D.T. Chandrasekar 5/69) lost to Jolly Rovers 334 in 89.1 overs (B. Indrajith 118, S. Ganesh 69, C. Senthil Kumar 41, G. Shailender 5/96); **Points:** Rovers 6 (19), MRC-A 0 (23).

**At Vinayaka Mission:** Singam Puli 175 & 187/4 in 75 overs (R. Ram Arvindh 60, U. Mukilesh 50) vs. Grand Slam 96 in 34 overs (M. Mathivanan 4/31).  
**At CSK-Guru Nanak:** Young Stars 445 in 147.2 overs (Aditya Varadharajan 108, A. Badrinath 105, V.K. Vineeth 46, Wilkins Victor 41, N. Kabilan 4/88) vs. Vijay 74/1 in 25 overs.  
**At RKM-Vivekananda:** Pristine 155 & 15/0 in 5 overs vs. SKM 299 in 107.5 overs (C. Hari Nishaanth 52, S. Swaminathan 70, Sudhan Sanjeevi Kandepan 83, Monish Satish 7/84).  
**At MRF-Pachaiyappa's:** Globe Trotters 453/8 decl. in 119.3 overs (D. Santhosh Kumar 48, P.S. Jaswanth 105, G. Ajitesh 89, S. Guru Raghavendran 100 n.o., Ashwanth Valthapa 4/148) vs. Swaraj 104/2 in 58 overs.

SNAPSHOTS

**van der Poel wins ninth stage; Pogacar leads**

USSEL: ‘The Flying Dutchman’ Mathieu van der Poel triumphed in a scramble for the finish line on stage nine of the Tour de France on Sunday, as the Alpecin-Premier Tech rider secured his first Grand Tour stage win of the year. Tobias Johannessen and Tom Pidcock finished second and third, while Slovenian four-time champion Tadej Pogacar crossed the line soon after to maintain his overall lead.

**Orange Dragons beats Yellow Challengers**

CHENNAI: Orange Dragons defeated Yellow Challengers by 14 runs in the TNCA Freyer Trophy women's T20 tournament on Sunday.  
**The scores:** Pink Warriors 108/7 in 20 overs (M.D. Thrushkaminii 31) lost to Red Rangers 112/4 in 18.5 overs (Roshini Rajasekaran 34 n.o., N.S. Subbaharini 35 n.o.). Orange Dragons 113/7 in 20 overs (A. Madhumitha Anbu 33) bt Yellow Challengers 99 in 19.2 overs (S.B. Aksara 33, Akshara Srinivasan 4/20). Blue Avengers 130/6 in 20 overs (M. U. Poojashrini 3/20) bt Purple Blazers 95 in 17.3 overs. Green Invaders 107/8 in 20 overs

lost to Silver Strikers 111/2 in 17.5 overs (Trisha Madhu 38 n.o., D. Hemalatha 45 n.o.).

**Suraj in last eight**

India's Suraj Chand beat Kuwait's Ammar Altamimi 6-11, 11-5, 11-5, 11-6 to reach the men's quarterfinals of the HCL Squash PSA Challenger Tour-Chennai at the Indian Squash Academy on Sunday.  
**Other results (pre-quarters)**  
**Men:** Om Semwal bt Shamil Wakeel (Sri) 7-11, 11-3, 11-6, 11-3; Joachim Chuah (Mas) bt Youssef Teleb (Egy) 11-7, 11-7, 11-3; Hugo Jaen (Esp) bt Islam Kouritam (Egy) 5-11, 11-2, 11-4, 9-11, 11-7; Md Syafiq Kamal (Mas) bt Harith Daniel (Mas) 11-9, 11-8, 8-11, 11-3; Salah Eltorghman (Can) bt Diwakar Singh 11-5, 11-3, 11-2; Wa Sern Low (Mas) bt Ayaan Vaziralli 11-8, 11-5, 11-9; Adham Roshdy (Egy) bt Yusuf Thani (Brn) 11-13, 11-5, 9-11, 11-6. **Women:** Unnati Tripathi bt Ananya Narayanan 10-12, 11-8, 11-7, 11-4; Sanya Vats bt Lisa Aitken (Sco) 11-7, 11-9, 11-8; Pooja Arthi Raghu bt Nirupama Dubey 11-5, 11-8, 8-11, 11-9; Rouqaia Othman (Egy) bt Chaewon Song (Kor) 11-5, 11-4, 11-3; Hwayeong Eum (Kor) bt Rui Jean Yek (Mas) 11-3, 11-4, 11-9; Rethika Seelan bt Anika Dubey 9-11, 11-5, 11-6, 10-12, 11-3; Hana Aladdin (Egy) bt Malak Samir (Egy) 3-11, 11-9, 9-11, 11-5, 11-1; Thanusaa Uthriam (Mas) bt Shameena Riaz 11-8, 11-8, 1-11, 11-6.

ENGAGEMENTS

**Cricket:** TNCA league, I div, sixth round: Nelson vs. Sea Hawks (Tagore); Singam Puli vs. Grand Slam (Vinayaka Mission); Young Stars vs. Vijay (CSK-Guru Nanak); Pristine vs. SKM (Vivekananda); Globe Trotters vs. Swaraj (MRF-Pachaiyappa's), day three, 9.15 a.m.; TNCA women's Freyer Trophy T20 tournament, Red Rangers vs. Blue Avengers (8.30 a.m.), Silver Strikers vs. Orange Dragons (1 p.m.), Gojan-B. Tagore Sports-TNCA City Schools u-16 tournament for C. Ramaswamy Trophy: St. Bede's-A' (Mylapore) vs. Olive Tree Global, GE-A; Ramachandra PS (Kottivakkam) vs. Santhome-A, Fomra-A; St. Bede's-B vs. St. Michael's Academy (GE-B); Sishya OMR (Thuraiyakkam) vs. Heartfulness International-A (Kolappakkam), Fomra-B, 8 a.m. Jawahar Vidyalaya-A vs. Heartfulness International-CBSE (Kolappakkam), GE-A; Heartfulness International-B vs. Vidya Mandir, Fomra-A. Don Bosco-B vs. Ebenezer MHSS (Korattur), GE-B; The PSBB Millennium-A (Gerugambakkam) vs. PSBB (Nungambakkam), Fomra-B, 1 p.m.

**Tennis:** RWD-TNTA inter-collegiate men and women championship, D.B. Jain College.

LIVE TELECAST

**England Women vs India Women:** One-off Test, Day 4, Sony Sports Ten 2 & LIV, 3.30 p.m.

D'artagnan wins Zavaray S. Poonawalla Bangalore Summer Derby

RACING

BENGALURU: P. Shroff-trained D'artagnan (Yash up) won the Zavaray S. Poonawalla Bangalore Summer Derby (2,000m), the stellar attraction of the races held here on Sunday (July 12). The winner is owned by Mr. & Mrs. Vijay B. Shirke & Mr. Jay V. Shirke rep. Horse Haven Breeding and Racing Pvt. Ltd., Mr. & Mrs. Farouq K. Rattoney rep. Hyperion Bloodstock Pvt. Ltd., Mr. Mehnosh H. Deboo, Mrs. Liane Luthria, Mr. Milan Luthria, Mrs. Daisy K.D.B. Mehta, Mr. Darashaw Keki Mehta rep. Darashaw Racing & Breeding Pvt. Ltd., Mr. & Mrs. Farouq K. Rattoney, Mr. Sameer F. Rattoney & Mr. Zaheer F. Rattoney rep. Hyperion Bloodstock Pvt. Ltd. Trainer Prasanna Kumar won three races on the day. Yash confidently kept his colt a handy third position till the bend before manoeuvring the mount from wide outside in the home stretch. D'artagnan responded well to the reminders, started galloping tremendously and overtook the leader Knotty Emperor while passing the last 100m to win resolutely. The BTC felicitated jockey P. Tre-



**Rewarding excellence:** Vijay B. Shirke and Milan Luthria, co-owners of D'artagnan, receiving Bangalore Summer Derby trophy from Zavaray S. Poonawalla and BTC chairman L. Shivashankar. K. MURALI KUMAR

vor for completing his 2000th win recently in Bangalore and Usha Stud Farm for 400th Classic win. **THE RESULTS:**  
**1. HYDERABAD SALVER (1,400M):** STARZELLA (Antony) 1, Sicyon (Yash) 2, Valiant Stream (Akshay K) 3 and Glorious Strides (Neeraj) 4. 3-1/4, 1-1/4 and 1/2. 1m, 23.37s. ₹13 (w), 10, 13 and 29 (p), SHP: 33, THP: 59, FP: 48, Q: 30, Trinella: 326/228, Exacta: 1,743/747. Favourite: Starzella. Owners: Capt. Jamshed J. Appoo, Mr. K. Narayan, Dr.

N. Swaroop Kumar, M/s. Blazing Saddles (PF) & Mr. Rustam Phiroze Mehta. Trainer: Prasanna Kumar.  
**2. INDIAN PATTERN COMMITTEE TROPHY (DIV. I) (1,200M):** IDI MINNAL (Md. Ashraf Reza) 1, A Great Buzz (Trevor) 2, Waltara (Aleemuddin) 3 and IL Volo (Vaibhav) 4. 2-1/4, Snk and 2-1/4. 1m, 12.37s. ₹160 (w), 28, 10 and 13 (p), SHP: 22, THP: 49, FP: 883, Q: 174, Trinella: 1,443/706, Exacta: 4,728/8,105. Favourite: A Great

Buzz. Owner and trainer: Mr. Aravind Ganapathy.  
**3. MUMBAI CUP (1,200M):** MASATO (A. Asbar) 1, Echoes Of Time (Neeraj) 2, Star Glory (M. Prabhakaran) 3 and Mandarin (Pavan) 4. Not run: Czar. 1/2, 3-3/4 and Nk. 1m, 10.99s. ₹46 (w), 15, 19 and 68 (p), SHP: 43, THP: 175, FP: 298, Q: 155, Trinella: 13,906/11,919, Exacta: 54,818 (c/o)/23,493. Favourite: Regal Reality. Owner: Mr. P. Arun Kumar. Trainer: S. John.  
**4. PATEL AND PATEL RACING LLP B.T.C. ANNIVERSARY CUP (1,400M):** MONEY BAGS (G. Vivek) 1, Ranquelino (Sandesh) 2, Once You Go Black (Yash) 3 and Galahad (Akshay K) 4. 4-1/4, 1/2 and Shd. 1m, 22.36s (record time). ₹16 (w), 10, 25 and 19 (p), SHP: 50, THP: 52, FP: 68, Q: 60, Trinella: 447/171, Exacta: 6,387/2,998. Favourite: Money Bags. Owners: Capt. Jamshed J. Appoo, Mr. K. Manoj Kumar, Mr. K. Kaliyaperumal & Mr. J. Ramesh. Trainer: Prasanna Kumar.  
**5. FIVE STARS SHIPPING MILLION (1,600M):** ASTERION (Akshay K) 1, Royal Legacy (Neeraj) 2, Sensuous (Suraj) 3 and Old Fashioned (Sandesh) 4. 1, 2-1/2 and 1. 1m, 36.61s. ₹25 (w), 12, 22 and 12 (p), SHP: 74, THP: 40, FP: 139, Q: 86, Trinella: 293/104, Exacta: 2,238/

1,172. Favourite: Asterion. Owner: Mr. C. Aryama Sundaram. Trainer: Karthik Ganapathy.  
**6. TURF AUTHORITIES OF INDIA TROPHY (1,800M):** YOUREMANORBORNE (Sandesh) 1, Winfield (Antony) 2, Oliver (Aleemuddin) 3 and Alamgir (Neeraj) 4. 3-3/4, 1/2 and 2. 1m, 49.22s. ₹20 (w), 12, 13 and 12 (p), SHP: 39, THP: 44, FP: 68, Q: 39, Trinella: 118/51, Exacta: 479/334. Favourite: Youremanorborne. Owner: Mr. B. Vijeth Bhandari. Trainer: P.S. Chouhan.  
**7. ZAVARY S. POONAWALLA BANGALORE SUMMER DERBY (2,000M):** D'ARTAGNAN (DEAUVILLE-EXCEPTION) YASH 1, Margaretta (Belardo-12ba) G. Vivek 2, Knotty Emperor (Gusto-Par Excellence) Suraj 3 and Moonvelt (Sanus Per Aquam-Electra) Trevor 4. 1/2, 1-1/4 and 3-3/4. 2m, 03.89s. ₹30 (w), 11, 10 and 14 (p), SHP: 40, THP: 33, FP: 57, Q: 20, Trinella: 125/87, Exacta: 706/378. Favourite: Margaretta. Owners: Mr. & Mrs. Vijay B. Shirke & Mr. Jay V. Shirke rep. Horse Haven Breeding and Racing Pvt. Ltd., Mr. & Mrs. Farouq K. Rattoney rep. Hyperion Bloodstock Pvt. Ltd., Mr. Mehnosh H. Deboo, Mrs. Liane Luthria, Mr. Milan Luthria, Mrs. Daisy K.D.B. Mehta, Mr. Darashaw Keki Mehta rep. Darashaw Racing & Breeding Pvt. Ltd., Mr. & Mrs.

Farouq K. Rattoney, Mr. Sameer F. Rattoney & Mr. Zaheer F. Rattoney rep. Hyperion Bloodstock Pvt. Ltd. Trainer: P. Shroff.  
**8. INDIAN PATTERN COMMITTEE TROPHY (DIV. II), 1,200M: LASYA (Bhavani S) 1, Agrador (Neeraj) 2, Supreme Success (Vishwa V) 3 and Lena (A. Asbar) 4. 1-3/4, Lnk and Lnk. 1m, 12.48s. ₹184 (w), 35, 14 and 24 (p), SHP: 26, THP: 57, FP: 1,456, Q: 347, Trinella: 9,284/4,547, Exacta: 8,401/2,118. Favourite: Lena. Owner: Mr. Kapil Dev M. Trainer: Aravind Ganapathy.  
**9. INDIAN PATTERN COMMITTEE TROPHY (DIV. III), 1,200M: POWER OF THE SEA (Antony) 1, Big B (M. Rajesh K) 2, SD Good Sam (R. Pradeep) 3 and Blind Faith (Md. Talib) 4. Not run: Character: 1/2, 3-3/4 and 3/4. 1m, 13.22s. ₹17 (w), 10, 16 and 44 (p), SHP: 40, THP: 120, FP: 56, Q: 44, Trinella: 1,386/998, Exacta: 11,222/2,219. Favourite: Power Of The Sea. Owners: M/s. Rapar Galloping Stars LLP, Mr. Anjan Kumar Rangaraj, Manjori Horse Breeders' Farm Pvt. Ltd. & Stride Livestock Pvt. Ltd. Trainer: Prasanna Kumar.  
Jackpot: ₹6,943.  
Runner-up: 1,974.  
Mini Jackpot: 2,251.  
Trebble (i): 2,678; (ii): 104; (iii): 737.****



# Abdication of the throne – the need to hit refresh and rejig

Once they succumbed unexpectedly to Ireland, India became diffident, almost second-guessing themselves. They didn't play the conditions well enough, they left their smarts behind at home



AFP & REUTERS

R. Kaushik

As far as reigns go, this will be hard to match. Impossible, one is tempted to say, given that the said reign was in the most unpredictable of formats. For 1,605 days, from 20 February 2022 to 11 July 2026, India ruled the Twenty20 International landscape with an iron fist, occupying the top perch in the ICC rankings, stacking up an enviable record that encompassed two T20 World Cup crowns (with a solitary defeat the sole, easily delible blot) and an unquestioned dominance that stemmed from fearlessness and the foresight to stack their sides with the personnel that would translate the mantra of intrepidity to glorious reality.

All good things in life must come to an end, however. Nothing is permanent, most certainly not ruling the roost in any of the three cricketing formats. That's the brutal truth, but the manner in which India abdicated the throne left a sour taste in the mouth. England, imperious England - would have said this even a decade back in white-ball internationals? - not just grabbed the throne from India, they positively brushed them aside, reducing them to a blubbery wreck that seemed to be weighed down by the pressure of their own expectations and by the heavy burden that one unchecked defeat after another is certain to impose.

Who would have imagined this scenario a fortnight back? Who would have indeed? Ireland first, for two matches that were supposed to be glorified practice sessions. Then England, over a five-game showdown largely predicted to be tight, tall-scoring contests with the visitors holding the edge because of their breathtaking batting riches, on full view during IPL 2026.

There were tall scores alright, but all of them came from the blazing bats of the opposition. Phil Salt, out of form? No matter. Jos Buttler, struggling for rhythm? Hey, we are here. Harry Brook, already in red-hot touch? Help yourself to more, skipper. India were supposed to be the main act, instead they served as the obliging support cast on which first Ireland and then England gorged, consigning the (then) No. 1 side in the world to six defeats in seven matches. Perhaps only because the one that didn't end in a loss was abandoned midway through.

India have harped on transition, on a new but not yet exciting phase in this format. Admittedly, they do have a new skipper - Shreyas Iyer wouldn't have imagined in his wildest nightmares that his stint at the top would begin this disastrously - and were without a couple of influential performers in Jasprit Bumrah and Hardik Pandya. But how often in the past have they not made light of these situations? How often have they not eked out extraordinary efforts from the not-so-celebrated stars-in-the-making? To say that they lost 0-2 to Ireland and were routed 4-0 by England just because

**Nothing is permanent, most certainly not ruling the roost in any of the three cricketing formats. That's the brutal truth, but the manner in which India was crushed in the T20I series in Ireland and England left a sour taste in the mouth**

Bumrah and Pandya weren't around will be disrespecting the skills and the mettle of those who were in the mix. India were outplayed; they were lame and timid and limp and almost fearful, the antithesis of the philosophy they have espoused for so long.

Doom-and-gloom time? For now, definitely, no matter that India will bounce back strongly because that's what they do. That's what they have done. But they find themselves in uncharted territory so far as the 20-over game is concerned, and it will be interesting to see how they rouse themselves, how they respond to the scent of battle next time around.

England were fabulous, that can't be denied. Where Ireland hoped to contest on even terms, England knew they were on an equal footing, at the very least. True, their familiarity with conditions helped, as did their knowledge of the Indian players with whom several in the English set-up interacted for more than two months just a little while back in the IPL, either from the same dressing or on opposite sides of the fence. But by the same token, the Indians knew what to expect from a Buttler or a Jofra Archer, and have had plenty of experience of playing both in England and against the likes of Brook and Sam Curran.

Once they succumbed unexpectedly to Ireland, India became diffident, almost second-guessing themselves. They didn't play the conditions well enough, they left their smarts behind at home and tried to adopt the same approach while wildly hoping for different results. England were clinical and ruthless, India traversed the other end of this spectrum and therefore it was no surprise that they were comprehensively put in their place. The negatives are piling up in the Gambhir-Ajit Agarkar coach-chief selector era, and while there is unlikely to be any earth-shattering decision when a review meeting is held by the Board of Control for Cricket in India at the conclusion of the three-match ODI series on July 19, a demand - a strident, relentless demand - for accountability will not be out of place.

#### Meaningful runs

Shreyas made up for a poor start with the bat in Ireland by stacking up meaningful runs in England, extending his IPL form to the world stage despite coming in cold to the T20I ecosystem. The first of two matches in Ireland was the Mumbaiaika's first 20-over international in more than two and a half years, during which time India played upwards of 60 games. Just to

be reintegrated with the setup after such a long gap would have been demanding; to compound matters, he was entrusted with the leadership of a world-beating outfit for the first time ever. Shreyas has termed the captaincy a privilege, which it certainly is, though very quickly, he has realised from bitter experience that it is a double-edged sword and that privilege can rapidly start to assume proportions of a millstone.

India made their task more difficult with several strange selection calls, not least the recall of leg-spinner Ravi Bishnoi. The little man had a tour to forget like many of his colleagues; his unforgivable foot-faults that gifted England with numerous free hits perfectly summed up India's woes. Bishnoi wasn't the lone culprit in that regard, with debutant Prince Yadav and Prasidh Krishna too guilty of overstepping and doling out freebies.

#### No impactful returns

Poor execution of bowling plans and tardiness in the field which resulted in dropped catches and runs squandered were, however, pushed a little into the background by the lack of impactful returns from the batters. India lost wickets in a bunch in the PowerPlay time and again, leaving the middle order with too much to do against an English pace-orientated attack that made optimum use of height, and therefore bounce and pace. Short deliveries became the go-to weapon for Archer and Josh Tongue with the new ball, while Curran, the master of deception, was excellent in the middle stages and extraordinary at the death.

By going too hard too soon without sizing up the conditions, India paid a heavy price. Shreyas stood tall with 218 runs, second across teams and only behind his English counterpart whose 229 runs came at a breathtaking strike-rate of 214.01. Of the rest, Abhishek Sharma shone in patches while making 131 runs, and Ishan Kishan and Tilak Varma had a half-century apiece but didn't do much otherwise to write home about. India's pronounced left-handedness - they had just one right-hander, Shreyas, in the top eight in the fourth fixture - hurt them badly, like it briefly threatened to during the T20 World Cup. But where they found a solution at home by dropping Rinku Singh and bringing Sanju Samson into the picture once they had defeated themselves into a corner after their defeat to South Africa in Ahmedabad, they were slow to respond (did they even respond?) in England and were therefore comprehensively overpowered.

Samson was the big disappointment of the tour, failing to build on his three wondrous efforts in the last three games of the World Cup when he answered the team's call with a rare streak of electric consistency. In Ireland and England, Samson went out of favour after just six runs in his first three outings as India unleashed the 15-year-old phenom,

Vaibhav Sooryavanshi. The teen sensation showed no more than glimpses of his destructive abilities and not too much should be read into returns of 42 runs at an average of 14. Samson averaged the exact same number in England and a disappointing 8.25 across the tour. Much has been made of Samson making way for Sooryavanshi for the second, third and fourth T20Is, and of being left out of the tour of Zimbabwe later this month when V.V.S. Laxman will travel as the head coach. In his heart of hearts, the well-backed right-hander from Keralam will acknowledge that he was a long way short of his best and that he has plenty of work ahead of him even if his heroics at the World Cup guarantee a longer than usual rope.

Truth to tell, India need not press the panic button for so many reasons, not least because the next World Cup is a long way away. These matches are good for the experience they provide - of what it takes to play well overseas, on pitches that have some assistance for the faster bowlers as opposed to on tracks that reduce the entire bowling fraternity to mere serfs - but the pathetic waving of the white flag without so much as a second thought can't be wished away. Most of the blame will, and should, fall on the players, but inconsistencies in selection and the unwillingness to allow players to settle into their roles cannot be overlooked.

New vice-captain Tilak is the classic example of being a victim of his own versatility, like K.L. Rahul has been in the two longer formats. In his last nine innings starting from the semifinal of the T20 World Cup, he has batted at No. 7 (once), No. 6 (four times) and No. 5. There is a great emphasis on 'entry points' in T20s, but sometimes, it helps having role clarity and one isn't certain that's the case with Tilak or even Washington Sundar, for that matter.

The England spanking is an eye-opener but also a blessing in disguise in that it has come so quickly after the last World Cup and with so much time to go to the next one. Lessons in humility, among other things, must be imbibed quickly if a one-off (as it stands) isn't to spiral into something much more alarmingly debilitating.

**Shreyas stood tall with 218 runs, second across teams and only behind his English counterpart Brook, whose 229 came at a breathtaking strike-rate of 214.01**

## THE GIST

The negatives are piling up in the Gambhir-Agarkar coach-chief selector era. However, there is unlikely to be any earth-shattering decision when a review meeting is held by the Board of Control for Cricket in India at the conclusion of the three-match ODI series

The pathetic waving of the white flag without so much as a second thought can't be wished away. Most of the blame will, and should, fall on the players, but inconsistencies in selection and the unwillingness to allow players to settle into their roles have not helped either

There is a great emphasis on 'entry points' in T20s, but sometimes, it helps having role clarity and one isn't certain that's the case with Tilak or even Washington





# Fading research hubs are stalling Kerala’s leap into the bio-economy

Kerala’s approach to science has changed, with basic research losing its place among public policy priorities; the State is attracted to projects that deliver visible and immediate outcomes, but that does not mean abdicating fundamental scientific research is okay; only such research can lead to long-term value creation

Biju Dharmapalan

Kerala has long taken pride in its literacy, scientific temper, and environmental consciousness. Home to the biodiverse Western Ghats and centuries of traditional knowledge, it should have emerged as India’s leading hub for biological research and the bioeconomy. But instead, many of its premier biological research institutions are today on the decline.

The reasons are clear: policy support for basic scientific research has eroded and institutions that were once internationally respected centres of excellence have become increasingly politicised.

The prime example is the Jawaharlal Nehru Tropical Botanic Garden and Research Institute (JNTBGRI) in Palode, in Thiruvananthapuram district. Established following the United Nations Conference on the Human Environment in 1972, JNTBGRI transformed nearly 300 acres of forest into one of Asia’s finest centres for tropical plant research and conservation. It has housed more than 50,000 plant accessions representing over 5,000 species, and was for most of its life a living repository of India’s botanical wealth. Its achievements ranged from documenting biodiversity and conserving endangered plants to pioneering research on medicinal plants and sustainable utilisation of biological resources.

The institute also demonstrated how scientific research could benefit society. Its researchers’ development of ‘Jeevani’, an anti-fatigue herbal formulation, based on the traditional knowledge of the Kani tribe became an internationally acclaimed model of access and benefit-sharing. In 2024, JNTBGRI also received the Botanic Gardens Conservation International’s Global Genome Initiative for Gardens Award.

These accomplishments were only possible because successive generations of scientists enjoyed the freedom, leadership, and institutional stability that long-term research demands. Today, however, a large fraction of experienced scientists have retired and JNTBGRI has not adequately recruited their successors. The number of research scholars has also dwindled. Together, the technical expertise the institute built over decades is at risk of disappearing.

This crisis at JNTBGRI is actually symptomatic of a larger change in Kerala’s approach to science. Basic research has slowly but surely lost its place among the State’s public policy priorities. State and local governments are understandably



The Jawaharlal Nehru Tropical Botanic Garden and Research Institute in Palode, Kerala, has demonstrated how scientific research can benefit society. JNTBGRI

attracted to projects that deliver visible and immediate outcomes – but that does not mean abdicating fundamental scientific research is okay. Only such research can lead to long-term innovation and value creation.

For example, discoveries in taxonomy, ecology, genetics, and plant biology usually take decades to turn into medicines, climate-resilient crops, and commercial technologies – but once they do, their effects become transformative. Short-term investments cannot achieve this.

Sadly, this retreat from basic research also comes at a time when the global bioeconomy is expanding at an unprecedented scale. Countries are investing heavily in biotechnology, natural products, synthetic biology, nutraceuticals, and biodiversity-based industries.

Kerala has the raw material to participate in this revolution, including biodiversity and trained scientists and institutions with decades of expertise; what it crucially lacks at this time is a coherent long-term vision.

## Conditions for success

Equally concerning is the gradual politicisation of scientific institutions. Research organisations thrive when scientific excellence determines leadership, recruitment, and institutional priorities. But when political considerations influence these decisions, the scientific culture inevitably suffers. Administrators replace academic leaders and long-term research planning gives way to a fondness for routine

management. Thus scientific autonomy gradually erodes and institutions become less attractive to talented young researchers.

Many of Kerala’s leading scientific institutions were built by visionary scientists who enjoyed considerable administrative autonomy, including because their credibility stemmed from academic excellence rather than political affiliation. That culture now appears to be declining, with the consequences going beyond laboratories. Scientific institutions are repositories of specialised knowledge that cannot be recreated overnight.

The State’s scientific ecosystem also suffers from a tendency to create new institutions while existing ones struggle with vacancies, ageing infrastructure, and declining manpower.

New centres certainly have their place but scientific excellence cannot be built merely by inaugurating new buildings or announcing ambitious missions. Institutions mature through sustained investment in people, infrastructure, and the research culture.

So instead, the State should focus on revitalising its established centres of excellence. Institutions such as JNTBGRI, the Kerala Forest Research Institute, and the Malabar Botanical Garden already possess internationally recognised collections, infrastructure, and scientific credibility. Strengthening these institutions will yield greater dividends than continuously expanding the institutional landscape without adequately supporting existing facilities.

Kerala also needs to rethink how it views biodiversity. Its forests, medicinal

plants, endemic species, and traditional knowledge systems are ecological assets, yes, but they also present significant economic opportunities. With appropriate safeguards for conservation and equitable benefit-sharing, biological research can support biotechnology, pharmaceuticals, natural cosmetics, and climate-resilient agriculture. Around the world, scientists and policymakers are increasingly recognising biodiversity as the foundation of future bioeconomies. Kerala should be leading this transformation.

Reversing the decline will also require a renewed commitment to basic science, transparent and merit-based institutional leadership, timely recruitment of young scientists, greater research autonomy, and stronger partnerships with universities and responsible industries.

The trajectory of JNTBGRI reflects Kerala’s changing relationship with science. The State once demonstrated that patient investment in scientific institutions could produce global recognition, conservation success and innovations that benefited society.

The forests of the Western Ghats continue to hold countless scientific discoveries waiting to be made. Whether Kerala remains at the forefront of that exploration or becomes a spectator to opportunities seized elsewhere will depend on the choices policymakers make today.

(Biju Dharmapalan is dean, Academic Affairs, Garden City University, Bengaluru and an adjunct faculty member at the National Institute of Advanced Studies, Bengaluru. [bijudharmapalan@gmail.com](mailto:bijudharmapalan@gmail.com))

## THE GIST

Policy support for basic scientific research has eroded and institutions that were once internationally respected centres of excellence have become increasingly politicised

The State’s scientific ecosystem suffers from a tendency to create new institutions while existing ones struggle with vacancies, ageing infrastructure, and declining manpower

Reversing the decline will require a renewed commitment to basic science, transparent and merit-based institutional leadership, timely recruitment of young scientists, greater research autonomy, and stronger partnerships with universities and responsible industries

## BIG SHOT



**A red blanket:** An aircraft drops fire retardant above wildfires in the Almeria province of Spain. After strong winds eased on Saturday, firefighters continued to beat back the flames that have forced 1,400 people to evacuate their homes as they spread through the mountains in the southeast. REUTERS

## WHAT IS IT?

# Eärendil-1: bright or blight?

Vasudevan Mukunth

On July 9, the U.S. Federal Communications Commission (FCC) authorised a company named Reflect Orbital to launch and operate a test satellite designed to deploy a large mirror in orbit around the earth, despite the controversy and debate surrounding its aims. Eärendil-1 — named for a character in the Tolkien fantasy epic *The Silmarillion* — will be a single satellite in a non-geostationary orbit fit with a “deployable, highly specular thin-film reflector”.

The reflector will be motorised and can be steered to different orientations. Its purpose is to reflect sunlight towards specific spots on the earth at nighttime. Reflect Orbital has said it intends to use this technology to extend the usable hours for solar panels and provide light during “critical operations” like emergency or humanitarian missions. The satellite will operate at an altitude of around 625 km with a high inclination of 88°. The FCC has granted a limited two-year license for the test. The approval itself followed significant debate.

Organisations like the American Astronomical Society (AAS) raised concerns regarding background skyglow and the mission’s potential to disrupt optical astronomy. In its order (DA 26-706), the FCC ruled while it regulates radiofrequency interference and orbital debris, the visual impact of reflected sunlight is



Eärendil-1 won’t be the first mirror in orbit. Shown here is Znamya-2, which Russia deployed as part of a series of orbital space mirror experiments in the 1990s. RSC ENERGIA

outside its statutory authority. Nonetheless, the FCC has also imposed some conditions. Reflect Orbital has to coordinate with NASA, the U.S. National Science Foundation, and the National Telecommunications and Information Administration to protect astronomy, and Eärendil-1 has to abide by specific duty cycles and conjunction angles to avoid interfering with other missions.

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# Text & Context

THE HINDU

## NEWS IN NUMBERS

### Number of persons who drowned in Germany last month

**99** Ninety-nine people drowned in Germany last month, the most since a record heatwave swept Europe in 2003, as per the official figures. Germany was among the nations hit by the June heatwave in western Europe, which set temperature records in several places. AFP

### Fund sought by Delhi CM for accelerating ownership scheme

**100** ₹ crore Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta has sought ₹100 crore from the Centre to accelerate the implementation of the PM-UDAY scheme, providing property rights to residents of 1,511 unauthorised colonies in the national capital, according to a statement. PTI

### Traditional water sources cleaned in Hamirpur district

**236** A campaign to clean the traditional water sources in Himachal Pradesh's Hamirpur district has restored 236 facilities so far, officials said. The campaign was launched to safeguard people from waterborne diseases during monsoon. PTI

### Number of SIR forms submitted in two days in Punjab

**30** lakh More than 30 lakh Punjab electors have submitted their enumeration forms during special camps organised Statewide over two days as part of special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls, Chief Electoral Officer (CEO) Anindita Mitra said on Sunday. PTI

### Deaths due to floods reported in Bangladesh

**44** At least 44 people have died in floods and landslides over the past week in Bangladesh, officials said Sunday, as rivers remained above danger levels and 2.5 lakh families were displaced. Overnight torrential rains inundated several areas in Dhaka. PTI

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# Why has China banned helium exports?

Why is helium emerging as a strategic resource? How vulnerable is the world to a helium supply shock? Why is it considered a critical input for future technologies? Why is storing and transporting helium so expensive? What makes it so hard to replace?

## EXPLAINER

Vasudevan Mukunth

**The story so far:** On July 10, the Ministry of Commerce and General Administration of Customs, China, has temporarily but immediately banned helium exports from the country. As of 4.30 pm IST on July 10, Beijing had not published any other information as to why it took this step now or its scope.

**Is China a major helium producer?** China imports more than 80% of its helium needs but produces only around 1.6% of the world's helium. The export ban follows an extended period of supply strained by Russia's export restrictions – where the Prime Minister needs to sign off on shipments through 2027 – and supply risks tied to heightened tensions in West Asia.

The world's major helium producers are the U.S. (meeting 43% of total supply), followed by Qatar, Russia, Canada, and Algeria. In 2024, the U.S. privatised its Federal Helium Reserve and, selling its assets to the Messer Group and no longer buffering shocks such as those due to the U.S.-Iran conflict.

The next year, the U.S. House Committee on Oversight and Government Reform launched an investigation into Messer's Chinese interests, stoking the risk of tit-for-tat measures. Which China's latest export ban could be.

After the U.S., Qatar has been meeting 33% of the demand, especially in Asia. After the conflict with Iran escalated, as medical chemist and *Science* columnist Derek Lowe put it, “one-third of global helium production is now literally bottled up behind the Strait of Hormuz, a much higher percentage than world oil production [where the situation is bad enough already].”

In this light, China's new export restriction could preserve the country's helium supply for its domestic chip



Helium can only be transported in vacuum-jacketed stainless steel vessels that are manufactured only by a few companies worldwide. GETTY IMAGES

manufacturers and its medical sector.

**How is helium obtained?** Helium is the second-lightest element, after hydrogen, and is not manufactured. It is a non-renewable resource generated deep in the earth's crust, where the radioactive decay of uranium and thorium atoms emits alpha particles, which capture electrons to form helium atoms.

Over millions of years, this helium migrates into the same reservoirs of natural gas, and they are extracted together. This said, natural gas is not processed to isolate the helium from it until the latter makes up at least 0.3% by volume.

But once it does, the gas is isolated using the fact that it has a different boiling point.

Some operators also recover helium from LNG plants and from the air but these quantities are too low to matter to the global demand. Helium for commercial use is usually at least 99.997% pure.

**What is helium used for?** Helium has an extremely low boiling point – negative 269°C – and does not participate easily in chemical reactions. These are good properties for a coolant that needs to cool the magnets in MRI machines, the silicon wafers in the semiconductor fabricating industry, and, increasingly, some of the devices used in quantum computers. Its small atoms mean the gas escapes easily through gaps that might be too small for oxygen or nitrogen atoms – so engineers use helium as a leak-detector.

Helium is also used in the process of drawing optical fibres to rapidly and uniformly cool molten glass and to displace oxygen or nitrogen from forming bubbles inside the material. Spaceflight organisations like ISRO, NASA, and SpaceX use helium to pressurise fuel tanks in rockets. Research and the tourism sector in many parts of the world also use helium to inflate balloons and airships.

According to the U.S. Geological Survey, laboratory use-cases account for

22% of the demand for helium, followed by controlled atmospheres and semiconductors (17%), lifting gas (17%), MRI scanners (15%), aerospace (9%), and detecting leaks (5%).

**How much does helium cost?** In June 2026, the spot price for highly pure helium in Northeast Asia had reportedly spiked to \$150-205 per thousand cubic feet, almost double what it was in late 2025. At least one major supplier, the U.S.-based industrial supplier Airgas, has invoked force majeure and tacked on surcharges of \$13.50 per hundred cubic feet to existing contracts. Liquid helium is by default expensive to store and transport because helium only liquefies at -269°C.

In fact, the helium supply chain as a whole is cost-intensive because purification, storage, and transport are each expensive and technically sophisticated. A mid- to large-scale purification and liquefaction facility will require more than \$100 million while smaller ones can cost around \$10 million, thanks to the need for corrosion-resistant alloys that can withstand ultra-low temperatures.

The gas can be stored in underground salt caverns, which reduce leaks significantly – but these formations are rare and developing a new one can cost more than \$200 million. It can also be stored as compressed gas or cryogenic liquid. The former typically costs up to \$10 million to build while bulk cryogenic liquid storage systems generally need between \$0.5 million and \$20 million depending on capacity. Then there are the operational expenses.

Finally, helium can only be transported in vacuum-jacketed stainless steel vessels – which are manufactured by relatively few companies worldwide, including several Chinese ones.

Finally, the contractor transporting the containers must also ensure they are delivered before the holding time expires, after which the helium will start boiling off into the atmosphere.

## THE GIST

▼ The export ban follows an extended period of supply strained by Russia's export restrictions – where the Prime Minister needs to sign off on shipments through 2027 – and supply risks tied to heightened tensions in West Asia.

▼ Helium is an important coolant in the semiconductor fabricating industry, where it removes heat from silicon wafers.

▼ The helium supply chain as a whole is cost-intensive because purification, storage, and transport are each expensive and technically sophisticated.

# How DDCs changed local governance in J&K?

What is at stake in the debate over local democracy in Jammu and Kashmir?

Tikender Singh Panwar

**The story so far:** The restructuring of Jammu and Kashmir's political and administrative framework through the constitution of District Development Councils (DDCs) has remained the subject of legal and constitutional debate. Formed in 2021, the DDCs completed their five-year term on February 24, 2026. With no fresh elections held and local government institutions remaining largely inactive in recent years, questions have resurfaced about the relevance of the DDC model. Introduced as a mechanism for direct local democracy, the DDCs are viewed by supporters as a step towards grassroots governance, while critics argue they have impeded rather than strengthened democratic decentralisation in the region.

**What do the 73rd and 74th Amendments provide for?** One of the core arguments presented for

the abrogation of Article 370 was the need to fully integrate J&K with the constitutional framework applicable to the rest of India.

A central element of this argument was the introduction of the 73rd and 74th Constitutional Amendment Acts, which provide for elected rural and urban bodies. This integration was intended to ensure regular, mandatory elections and empower grassroots democracy.

**How is local governance structured?** The standard constitutional framework operates on a clearly defined multi-tier electoral system where citizens directly elect their local representatives:

Urban areas: Municipal Corporations, Municipal Councils, and Nagar Panchayats.

Rural areas: A three-tier structure comprising Gram Panchayats (Village Pradhans), Block Development Councils (BDCs), and District-level bodies (Zila Parishads).

Mandated under Article 243ZD of the

Constitution, the District Planning Committee (DPC) is envisaged as a coordinating body that brings together development plans prepared by panchayats and municipalities and integrates them into a comprehensive district-level plan.

Unlike an independent executive authority, the DPC is intended to function as an institutional mechanism that reflects priorities generated by elected local bodies and facilitates bottom-up planning. In this sense, it is designed to strengthen democratic decentralisation by aggregating local mandates rather than exercising authority over them.

However, while the constitutional framework assigns a key role to DPCs in district-level planning, their functioning has been uneven across the country, with many remaining largely inactive, barring a few exceptions such as Kerala.

**How do DDCs differ from DPCs?** The DDCs were established in J&K through an executive order rather than a

legislative process. While the government presents DDCs as directly elected bodies that strengthen grassroots democracy, it is contended that the model contains major contradictions within the governance framework.

Critics argue that the DDC structure bypasses existing institutions such as Zila Panchayats and urban local bodies. Unlike the DPC, which is intended to aggregate development priorities emerging from lower tiers of government, the DDC functions as a parallel administrative authority with executive and developmental powers. This blurs the relationship between the electorate and the actual exercise of power.

The key distinction is that the DPC seeks to strengthen local democracy by consolidating mandates generated from the ground up, whereas the DDC operates from above, competing with lower tiers of governance and functioning as an instrument of centralised bureaucratic control rather than democratic decentralisation.

The DDC structure raises concerns about unequal representation. The allocation of seats across districts does not adequately reflect variations in population, thereby diluting the principle of uniform political weight.

For instance, Srinagar, with a population of roughly 12 lakh, and Kishtwar, with around 2.5 lakh residents, are allocated the same number of DDC members. This creates an imbalance where the political voice per capita is drastically skewed.

The DDCs are being compared to the “special purpose vehicles” used in Smart City projects. They create an illusion of decentralisation, but act as capital-driven, bureaucratically managed structures. Since DDCs can easily jettison legislatively approved local initiatives, they function as a governance substitute rather than a governance supplement.

The creation of 280 DDC members across J&K has established a form of parallel ‘parliament’ in disguise. Historically, in politically fragile regions, central authorities have often sought to weaken provincial or State-level assemblies by backing district-level entities.

With the J&K State Assembly absent or weakened for years, the DDC framework has allowed key functions and financial powers that would ordinarily rest with elected legislators and local panchayats to remain concentrated under Union administration control.

**What is the way forward for local democracy in J&K?**

Genuine local democracy cannot be reduced to an administrative or legal exercise; it is fundamentally a political question. True decentralisation requires the restoration of the DPC model envisaged under the 73th and 74th Constitutional Amendments, ensuring financially empowered and grounded local governments accountable to the State's electorate, rather than an administrative architecture serving centralised union control.





**OPENAI VS.  
ANTHROPIC:  
WHO WINS?**

# Has OpenAI's GPT-5.6 class beaten Anthropic's Fable-class models?

John Xavier

Just over a week after Fable 5 came back online for all users, OpenAI unveiled its own next-generation family: GPT-5.6 Sol, Terra, and Luna. Rather than a single flagship, OpenAI split the release into three capability tiers priced separately

It rewards a model that can read carefully, navigate something large and unfamiliar, and make a precise, contained

Apart from the GPT-5.6 family of models, the company also announced

For teams weighing cost per completed task rather than raw benchmark scores this efficiency gap may be a deciding factor than which model tops any individual leaderboard. Though, as with the Codex-versus-neutral-harness comparison above, it's worth checking whether that efficiency holds up outside OpenAI's own tuned environment before betting a production workflow on it.

## A quiz on ICC Hall of Famers to mark the induction of Sourav Ganguly and Anjum Chopra

V.V. Ramanan

### QUESTION 1

#### QUESTION 4

The Sri Lankan legends

**QUESTION 7**  
Name the Pakistani cricketer who was honoured posthumously in 2022 for his feats.



**Visual question:** Name this only woman inducted into the Hall of Fame. REUTERS

### Answers to the previous day's daily quiz:

1. An easy one. A translation of the *Odyssey* by this scholar has been subject to controversy ever since Mr. Nolan mentioned it in an interview. Name the scholar. **Ans: Emily Wilson**
2. Ancient Greek plays were categorised into two forms: comedies and tragedies. Aristotle considered this the important element of a play. Name it. **Ans: Mythos (Plot)**
3. This Greek tragic character gouges his eyes out after learning a terrible truth. Name the character, the play, and the tragedian who wrote the play. **Ans: Oedipus; Oedipus Rex, Sophocles**
4. The *Odyssey* is an epic poem written by Homer, considered to be a foundational work of classical literature. However, this ancient Greek philosopher was of the opinion that poetry and theatre were morally corrupt, and that poets should be banished. Name him. **Ans: Plato**
5. The *Iliad* is also an epic poem by Homer. What is its famous opening line? **Ans: "Sing, O goddess, the anger of Achilles..."**
6. Visual: This rap artist stars in Nolan's *Odyssey*. Name him and the role he plays in the film. **Ans: Travis Scott; The Bard**

## Early Birds

Tamal Biswas | Sitaram Saharay | Pulkit Sathe | Kamal Pandey |  
Pankaj Gharde



## KNOW YOUR ENGLISH

*He works for  
a prestigious  
law firm*

She takes after her grandmother,  
especially in her love for music

**S. Upendran**

“The final ‘ous’ sounds like the ‘ous’ in ‘famous’.”

“To retain someone like her, they would have had to double her salary. Whenever Sunitha goes to a restaurant, she always tips the waiter handsomely.”  
 “That’s easy to do when you get a handsome cheque every month.”  
*upendrankye@gmail.com*

## Word of the day

## Tacit:

implied by or inferred from actions or statements

**Synonyms:** implied, hinted

**Usage:** *There was a tacit agreement that he would pay off the loan.*

**Pronunciation:** [newsth.live/tacit](https://newsth.live/tacit)

International Phonetic Alphabet: /ˈtæs.ɪt/

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